1:43 AM

By Brieleigh Wescott

Prologue

There is nothing quite like grief. It doesn’t come like you would expect it to. It's not like a wave that crashes into your life one moment and then recedes back into the unceasing waters. It's not like a storm in which some days you can brace yourself for it, while other days it seems to form out of nowhere. No, it's not like that at all. While grief does come and go, it's never dramatic. Instead, it moves like a shadow. Sometimes it's as clear as a midsummer day, while other times it is barely a whisper. On a cloudy day, you can almost forget you ever had a shadow. While the shadowless may assume that it would be great to be naive to the darkness below. What they don’t realize is that the cruelest thing about grief is that it lets you forget, just for a moment. In those seconds, you may feel happy, but when the sun comes out, and the shadow reappears, a level of guilt masters you.

Those of us with a shadow are forever connected to it. Forever consumed by it. It can become an addiction to master your shadow. To understand it. To tame it. To a shadow, time is its greatest enemy. With each passing day, the shadow seems to fade. Memories of its creator wither like flowers on a nightstand.

Lana Davis gained her shadow on the night of February 22nd, 2025, when her husband was killed by a 19-year-old boy driving home from a night of drinking with his friends. Ever since that fateful call, a dark shadow has moved with her, almost controlling her each and every thought. It had been 9 months since the accident, and it finally seemed the flowers were beginning to wilt and the shadow was growing dim. That was the illusion, until the night of November 18th. The night that made Lana’s shadow clearer than ever.

The First Call

Chapter 1

November 2025

In the darkness of her bedroom, Lana enjoyed counting the number of times the smoke detector blinked before releasing its mechanical chirp. The pattern was always constant. A blink and then a pause. A blink and then a pause. Then that persistent reminder that she needed to go change its batteries.

Beep.

For some reason, that tiny pulse of light was oddly comforting. It performed its duty without emotion and carried on each and every night, despite lacking a 9-volt battery. As silly as it sounded, that little green light was a reminder to her that she was still there. Even after everything, the accident, the phone calls checking in, the funeral, and the weeks that followed, her heart continued to beat inside her chest. It refused to stop just because the world had shattered around it. Just like that little light.

Some nights, that fact felt marvelous, but other nights, like tonight, it just felt evil.

She shifted beneath the covers and rolled onto her side. The mattress dipped slightly with her weight and seemed to memorize the shape of her body. Ever since the accident, sleep had been something she flirted with but could never commit to. She would lie awake for hours, lost in her thoughts. A sigh escaped as she rested her cheek against the cold silk pillow.

The smoke detector blinked once more.

A blink and then a pause. Instead of that chirp she was so used to, the sound that followed wasn't so comforting. It was different. It was something that broke the rhythm and made Lana lose track of how many sheep she had counted as she drifted toward sleep.

BUZZ.

Lana's eyes instantly opened.

It came again, the jarring buzz of her cell phone vibrating throughout the room. She never got calls, especially at that hour.

She sat up slowly, rubbing her eyes, pretending for just a moment that she had been pulled from a deep slumber rather than dragged out of a shallow rest. Her feet slipped into slippers as she stood, the floor cold beneath the thin soles. She walked across the hardwood floors with the quietness she had mastered over the last few months. The quietness that she often found necessary, even though she lived alone.

The phone buzzed again.

A second ring.

BUZZ.

Her old flip phone sat on the nightstand. Its plastic casing was dull and worn, and her best friend called it "tragically uncool" at least once a week, but Lana didn't care. It worked.

A third ring.

BUZZ.

As she walked closer, she hesitated. Something in her gut twisted as her heart thudded in her chest. She glanced at the clock.

1:43 a.m.

A fourth ring.

BUZZ.

Before she could properly think, she pressed the cold plastic phone to her ear.

“Hello?” she said.

All that came from the other line was silence. Not static or a familiar voice. Not even a breath.

Just silence.

She almost hung up. Then, from the other line, a voice came.

“Hello, Lady Bug.”

As if gravity had suddenly doubled, Lana dropped to her knees.

The fall wasn’t graceful. It was violent, like her own shadow had reached up and yanked her down. Her phone slipped from her hand and hit the hardwood with a sickening smack that destroyed the silence around her.

CRACK.

The collision echoed throughout the apartment like a gunshot, warning her of danger. Lana barely noticed because the true impact wasn't the phone, but the name. The nickname came from the voice of someone who shouldn't have been able to speak at all.

Her skin prickled, and her stomach sank. She felt like the walls were closing in around her. She could feel her pulse everywhere, her throat, her fingertips, the inside of her skull.

The voice, his voice, still whispered in her ear, but it was not possible. It couldn't be.

People say that a loved one's voice is the first thing forgotten after they pass, but she knew what she heard. She knew only one person who called her by that nickname.

The voice on the other end of the phone was David. The only problem was, David had been dead for nine months.

Without thinking, Lana sprang forward to get to the phone. Her hands scrambled as they slipped on its smooth surface.

It slipped once, twice, before her fingers were finally able to grasp its cold metal bottom. Finally, with a desperate breath, she pulled it back to her ear.

"David," she said.

All she heard in reply was static. He was once again gone, and beneath her, the lucidity of her shadow began to sharpen.

In defeat, she rested her phone back down on the old wooden desk. Her husband's flannel, David’s flannel, was still draped over the chair in the corner. She didn’t look at it. She couldn’t. She just sat on the cold floor and felt nothing but confusion and grief.

Chapter 2

September 2018

The first time Lana Davis saw David Johnson, she wasn't looking for him. She wasn't looking for anyone, actually. Just the bookstore that recently opened in her new college town. Which, in her defense, was not even on Google Maps yet and was hidden snugly between a Five Guys and an abandoned Blockbuster that had sat empty for the last four years.

She stood on the sidewalk in front of a large statue of a Panther, her college mascot, with her tote bag slipping off her shoulder, squinting at the map on her phone. She'd already checked it five times but hoped it might suddenly rearrange itself out of pity.

It did not.

A cool breeze weaved through the trees, carrying with it the withering summer smell of freshly cut grass, sunscreen, and overpriced coffee. Orientation week had been a blur. So many new people, most of whom she knew she would never talk to again. So many majors she had never even heard of. So many colors. Again. So many colors.

Lana kept thinking the same thing over and over.

How can anyone be this excited to be somewhere new? Somewhere unknown?

Posted above the police station to her left stood a sign that read WELCOME HOME FRESHMAN in bright orange and green, as if everyone already belonged here. Lana didn't feel like she belonged anywhere yet.

She tugged nervously at the sleeve of her oversized sweatshirt. She had stolen it from her older brother before leaving. It swallowed her hands and made her feel safer, like she could hide inside it and pretend she was home. She started her quest once again to find this bookstore. About forty-five minutes passed before Lana found herself back standing in front of the panther. Its eyes seemed to judge her, questioning how she could even get into this university without basic navigational skills.

Right then, something small landed gently on her sleeve. She was startled and froze, but looked down at her arm. A tiny ladybug sat there, bright red against her gray sweatshirt like a dot of spilled paint.

“Oh,” she whispered. “Hi.”

She watched it for a second, oddly mesmerized by the contrast between its bright red wings and its dark spots. It crawled slowly and unbothered, its little legs tickling her skin through the fabric.

“They say it's cursed,” a voice said from an unknown location. Lana whipped around so fast her tote bag swung forward and smacked her hip. Her eyes widened, and she stood a little straighter out of reflex.

Behind her was a tall guy with dark brown hair. His backpack hung loose on one shoulder, and for some reason, for some insane reason, he was wearing a red flannel sweater in eighty-five-degree weather.

He nodded toward the panther statue as if he were a college ambassador about to give a tour to a group of admitted students.

“Apparently,” he continued, “when the university first opened, they had a real panther. His name was Pete.”

Lana stared at him. “A real panther?”

He nodded. “A real panther.”

He stepped closer, lowering his voice. “Pete used to get visitors all the time until one day, the president banished him to live in solitude.”

“That’s… sad,” Lana said, even though she wasn’t sure she believed any of this.

“Oh, it gets worse,” he said. His eyes flicked briefly to her sleeve, at the ladybug still sitting there, then back to her face.

“Legend has it,” he continued, “Pete’s spirit lives inside this statue now. And whenever someone is trying to find something important...” He paused and smiled. “...he teleports them back here.”

Lana blinked and let out a chuckle. “Teleports?”

He nodded. “Oh yeah. The same thing happened to me last year. I tried to find my first class and ended up here seven times. I started thinking I’d died and this was my afterlife.”

Lana laughed a little. Then she said, “Well, I’m actually done with my classes for the day. I’m just looking for the bookstore. I heard they opened up a new one this week.”

“Well, it’s your lucky day,” he said. “That’s where I’m headed. You want a hand getting out of the infinite time loop?” he said, his hand reaching for hers.

Lana released a heavy sigh, then looked this mystery man dead in the eyes. “That's a cute story there, Paul Bunyan, but I don’t need your help. I can figure it out.” She began to walk away, but he followed her.

“Well, I watched you walk past that corner eight times in the last twenty-six minutes, so I’d beg to differ,” he said, amusement dancing in his voice.

Lana stopped and looked back at him. “You watching me or something?”

David smirked. “It’s not every day you see someone as pretty as you on campus, especially at a Tech school.”

Lana looked down at the ladybug still there, trying to ignore the heat in her cheeks. The little bug crawled slowly, and she lifted her arm slightly to watch it.

“Ladybug,” he said.

Lana looked back up. “What?”

He pointed at her. “That’s you. Ladybug.”

Lana’s eyebrows scrunched. “That’s not my name.”

“No,” he said, “but it could be.”

Looking at this stranger in front of her, Lana was hesitant. On one hand, she really wasn't the flirtatious type. She came to college to get a degree, get a job, and maybe make some memories along the way. She definitely was not looking for a boy to become an obstacle on this journey.

But looking at him made her feel something different. The way his mocha eyes lit at the sight of her smile. The way he filled the space with so much positivity and confidence. She was attracted to him. She wanted to learn more about him. She should've left, but instead she reached out her hand to meet his. "My name is Lana."

The stranger smiled. "Well, Miss Lana, would you give me the pleasure of guiding you to the bookstore?"

Lana smirked at his charm and replied, "Can I get your name first, Mr. Cursebreaker?"

His smile softened, like he liked that.

"David," he said. "My name is David."

Lana didn't know how she got back to her dorm. It felt like her legs moved all on their own with a little skip added to them, which she would sigh at every time she realized it. Her tote bag bounced against her hip with every step, and the ladybug was still there.

The campus was louder now. Groups of freshmen passed her walking way faster than her, laughing too hard and talking too fast. Someone yelled across the courtyard. Someone else

dropped something heavy, and it clanged against the sidewalk. But all Lana could hear was the way David had said her nickname. The way the words slipped so smoothly out of his soft lips, only to reveal such a beautiful smile she swore it could be hung up in a dentist's office.

Ladybug.

The word still sat on her skin. Or in this case, on her sleeve.

She finally reached her dorm and shoved open the door to the common room. The air inside smelled like cheap perfume and someone's microwaved mac and cheese. She walked down the hallway, turned the corner, and spotted Charlotte sitting cross-legged on the floor outside their room.

Her suitcase was open, and clothing was spilling out everywhere. A half-empty iced coffee sat beside her as she held up a pair of black boots in one hand and a pink bedazzled pillow in the other.

Charlotte looked exhausted, and Lana could tell. Her eyeliner was already smudged, and no one hated cleaning more than her best friend. "Where have you been?" Charlotte said. "I texted you thirteen times."

Charlotte looked up to meet Lana's gaze, then tilted her head. "Oh."

"Oh, what?"

Charlotte pointed at her, as if she were trying to diagnose her. "You look… disturbed."

Lana dropped her tote bag onto the floor, and it landed with a soft thud. Charlotte could always read her. She guessed that having the same best friend since the third grade was both a benefit and a curse.

"I am disturbed," she replied.

"Okay, slay. Sit." Charlotte nodded and gestured to the ground in front of her.

Lana went to sit on the floor beside her. She pulled her knees to her chest and just stared straight ahead. She finally began, "I just met the weirdest person."

"Define weird."

"Like… weird-weird. I don't know, just weird."

Charlotte leaned forward. "Okay, well, was it a man?"

Lana blinked. "Yes."

Charlotte shifted closer, resting her elbow on her knee. "Oh. Tell me everything, starting from the beginning. Was he hot or ugly?"

"Charlotte."

"What?" Charlotte shrugged. "It's important information. I need to know if we're dealing with a hot serial killer or an ugly one."

"He's not a serial killer."

Charlotte smirked. "We don't know that yet."

Lana exhaled and rubbed her forehead. “Okay. Fine. So I was trying to find this bookstore.”

Charlotte nodded. “Naturally.”

“And I kept ending up at the panther statue.”

Charlotte made a face. “That statue is terrifying. It looks like it wants to eat you alive and then judge you while doing it.”

“Yeah, I somehow agree with that,” Lana said quickly, constantly being reminded of why they were best friends. “Okay, then this guy comes up behind me and tells me the statue is cursed.”

“Okay. So what I am hearing is that he is mentally ill.”

Lana laughed and threw her arms up. “That’s what I thought!”

Charlotte pointed at her immediately. “You laughed. So he’s hot.”

Lana went red. “I did not laugh because he’s hot.”

“Okay. Whatever. Continue, I am invested.”

Lana stared at the wall across from them to try and remember the exact story. “He said the panther’s spirit lives inside the statue, and then he offered to take me to the bookstore because he watched me walk past the same corner like eight times.”

“He watched you?”

Lana flinched a little. “It sounds creepy when you say it like that.”

“It is creepy,” Charlotte said, voice firm. “Why was he watching you?”

Lana shrugged. “I don’t know. He said it was because I was pretty.”

Charlotte went still. Lana went still, too. They stared at each other for one long second.

Then Charlotte’s mouth dropped open. “HE SAID YOU WERE PRETTY?”

“Charlotte, stop.”

“Lana Davis. You have been here for, what, a week, and a man has already called you pretty?”

Lana’s face burned. “I don’t know, it wasn’t like... he just... I don't.”

“Oh my God. You’re flustered,” Charlotte interrupted her stutter.

“I am not flustered!”

Charlotte leaned back slightly, studying her like a scientist. “You’re flustered. This is a new one!”

Lana groaned and dropped her forehead onto her knees. “This is not huge.”

Charlotte poked her leg. “It’s huge because you don’t talk to men.”

“I talk to men.”

Charlotte raised a brow. “When?”

Lana lifted her head slightly. “At Starbucks.”

“That’s not talking. That’s ordering.”

Lana huffed. “Whatever.”

Charlotte smirked. “Okay. Tell me what he looks like.”

“He’s tall.”

“Okay.”

“He has dark brown hair.”

Charlotte nodded again. “Okay.”

“And he was wearing a flannel. Like in this heat, he chose to wear a flannel.”

Charlotte gave a judging look. “That’s either a red flag or a green flag. I just don’t know which one yet.”

“It was… kind of cute,” Lana admitted quietly.

Charlotte slapped her knee as if she’d just won the lottery. “YES.”

Lana shoved her. “Stop!”

They both laughed. “Okay, okay, okay. What else?”

“He… called me Ladybug.”

Charlotte stopped laughing. Her expression shifted into something that could only be described as confused. “Ladybug?” she repeated.

Lana nodded. “Yeah. Because one landed on my sleeve.”

Charlotte glanced down at Lana’s sweatshirt like she was checking for it now. Lana lifted her arm slightly. The ladybug was still there. Charlotte stared at it for a second.

Then she said, “That’s suspicious.”

Lana blinked. “Suspicious?”

Charlotte pointed at the ladybug. “Yes. Because why is it still there? Bugs don’t do that.”

Lana stared. “It’s just a ladybug.”

Charlotte looked at her with full seriousness. “Lana. That bug is either a sign from the universe or a government drone.”

Lana burst out laughing. Charlotte smiled slightly, like she was satisfied she had gotten it out of her. “Okay. Good. You needed that.”

Lana wiped at her eyes quickly. “I’m fine.”

Charlotte’s voice got quieter. “I know.”

Lana looked at her then, really looked.

Charlotte always acted tough and unemotional. She gave the vibe that she didn’t care about what was going on in the world and just went with the flow. She was simply easy to read.

But Lana was the opposite. To most people in her life, she was a closed book, with emotions so hard to read they might as well have been hieroglyphics. Charlotte, however, had this way of seeing right through her anyway, like how Bard in The Hobbit knew there was one place on Smaug's chest where the scales didn't cover him. But instead of killing Lana with a black arrow, she just shot her with love, comfort, and an insane amount of sarcasm.

Charlotte nudged her gently. "So what happened after?"

Lana inhaled slowly. "He offered to take me to the bookstore."

"Did you go?"

Lana hesitated again.

"LANA."

"I mean... I did go, but we only stayed for like twenty minutes because I was hungry. Oh, and he did help me pick out a book."

Charlotte chuckled. "Wow. Look at you trying to play hard to get."

"He probably didn't like me like that."

"He is a man. What man wouldn't want you? Especially the flannel ones."

Lana rolled her eyes. Charlotte leaned back against the wall and took a sip of her iced coffee.

"So," she said, voice calm, "did he ask for your number?"

Lana blinked with a side of disappointment. “No.”

“Hmm, okay, so he’s either respectful of your privacy or just uninterested.”

Lana’s chest tightened, for she didn’t want the second option to be correct.

Charlotte immediately noticed. “Oh my God. You wanted him to ask.”

“No, I did not.”

Charlotte pointed. “Your face is lying.”

Lana groaned and slid down the wall like she wanted to melt into the carpet. “I hate this.”

Charlotte smiled, softer now. “No, you don’t.”

“I do.”

“Okay. You hate it, but it’s still kinda cute.”

Lana’s voice was barely audible. “He was kinda cute.”

Charlotte gasped like she’d been waiting her whole life for that sentence. “OH MY GOD.”

Lana covered her face with her hands. “Please stop.”

Charlotte bumped her shoulder. “Welcome to college, Lana.”

Lana stared down at the ladybug on her sleeve. It crawled slowly like it was uninterested in the whole world around it. Like it didn't care about fear, or new places, or being lost. Lana whispered as if someone was watching, "Maybe I'm cursed."

Charlotte didn't even hesitate. "Yeah. Probably."

Lana looked at her, startled.

Charlotte smirked. "I'm kidding, obviously. It's more likely it's a drone."

Lana rolled her eyes, but she was smiling, and for the first time since she got to campus, the unknown didn't feel quite as terrifying.

After hours of talking in the living room with Charlotte, Lana finally went back to her little dorm room. She set her tote on her twin bed and lit a lavender-scented candle on her nightstand.

She pulled the poetry book out of her bag again, the one David helped her pick out in the bookstore. The cover was plain and soft, with ivory vines that contrasted sharply with the onyx background.

She flipped it open when something slipped out and fluttered to the floor. She stared down at the small piece of paper and slowly picked it up.

It looked like a bookmark, but not like one the store would sell. It was just a torn strip of brown paper, like it had been ripped from a grocery bag in a hurry.

On it, in messy handwriting, it read:

Ladybug,

In case you get lost again.

—David

And underneath…

A phone number.

It wasn't creepy. She was happy that he didn't put her on the spot. He wanted to give her a way out, but Lana wasn't going to take it. She texted him that night, and that was only the beginning.

Chapter 3

November 2025

The morning light crept through the woven curtains like it was sneaking in to start the new day. Lana stood in the kitchen, feeling the cold tile floor against her bare feet. She held a small chipped cup with scratched-up letters that spelled out “World's Best Girlfriend.” David had gotten it for her after only a month of dating. At the time, she thought it was silly, but now it was one of the little things that made her feel close to him.

She moved the cup up to her lips, took a sip of the warm green tea, then placed it on the kitchen table. She couldn’t stop thinking about last night. About the call and the voice she heard on the other end.

She didn’t know if she wanted it to be real or what to even make of the whole situation. Her feet carried her toward the living room. She needed to prove that last night was real and not just a dream, or at least find something to prove it was all in her head.

Her fingers rubbed against the inside of her sweatshirt pocket as she passed that blinking light above the window and walked toward the flannel draped on the chair. As she approached the desk…

Crack.

A sharp pain shot through her heel, and she jolted her foot up with a hiss, grabbing the side of the chair to steady herself. The pain wasn't horrible, but she sighed at the thin drips of blood that started to stain the light wooden floor, blooming like ink from a broken pen.

Rubbing her finger along the curve of her foot, she picked out the foreign object: a small piece of glass no bigger than a dime. She winced as she pulled the glass from her foot and slowly grounded herself back in front of the desk. Holding the shard up into the sun, it reflected the warm morning light directly into her eyes.

She scanned around her for the source of the glass and froze when she found her phone face down on the wooden desk, right where she remembered leaving it the night before. She slowly turned over the phone to discover that a piece of the top corner was missing. A piece the size of a dime.

Her heart skipped a beat. She thought last night was a dream, but there was now blood on the floor and glass in her hand that proved something different.

Lana stood there for a long moment, staring at the broken corner of her phone. She allowed the glass shard to travel around and around her fingers as if it were a toy. Her foot throbbed, pulsating with every strong pounding of her heart. She carefully picked up the phone. The plastic casing was warm from the sunlight coming through the curtains. The crack in the corner spidered outward. Her thumb hovered over the button.

So she knew that she was on her phone last night, but maybe she was just hearing voices? Checking the call log meant one of two things. Either it would be there, and there would be

proof. Clean and simple. Black and white. Or it wouldn't be, and Lana would have to face the fact that reality wasn't what she had always believed.

She opened the phone, and the screen glowed a dull blue. She clicked into the call history as her heart shook against her ribs like it was trying to break its way out of its bony prison. Her thumb scrolled once, and she found…

Nothing.

She stopped for a moment to catch her breath, then scrolled again.

Still nothing.

Her stomach dropped so fast it made her feel sick. The call should have been there. It should've been the top call, stamped with the time, but it wasn't.

The last call on her phone was from a week ago: a pharmacy reminder. Before that, an unknown number had been trying to sell her an extended car warranty. Before that, Charlotte's wife asked for advice on which perfume she should buy for her for their anniversary.

Lana continued to stare at the screen. Her fingers tightened around the phone so hard her knuckles went pale. "No," she whispered.

Her thumb scrolled again, more frantic now, as if the call might appear if she searched hard enough. But the log didn't change.

Lana felt her throat tighten. Her eyes stung again, but she refused to cry. She refused to let herself fall apart over this. Whether it was real or not, it wasn't bringing David back. She kept

telling herself that it was probably just a prank, or maybe she was so sleep-deprived it was a lucid dream.

But how did that explain the broken phone? Wouldn't she know if she was sleepwalking or going crazy? She wanted to forget about it and imagine it was just some crazy dream, but she couldn't. Her gut was telling her it was real. She knew his voice. It was real.

Her hands were shaking now, and she didn't know what to do with them. She wiped her palm on her sweatshirt, then reached for her tea. The mug was still warm.

Her eyes flew around the apartment, only to land on the flannel draped over the chair in the corner. She then grabbed her work phone. She rarely used it because she loved the feeling of older things. Her thumb hovered over Charlotte's name.

Charlotte Bennett. Her best friend. The one person in the world who would tell Lana she was insane without being worried about hurting her feelings.

Lana clicked the contact. The screen waited for a moment, and then she started typing:

Lana: I had the weirdest dream last night.

She stared at it. Then deleted it. "Dream" sounded wrong. "Dream" sounded like she wasn't sure, and she was sure.

She typed again:

Lana: Are you awake?

Then paused. Charlotte would ask why and call immediately. She would get all worried, and she didn't want that either.

Her thumb hovered again. Finally, she decided on something simple:

Lana: Can we get coffee today?

She stared at the message while her finger hovered over the send button. Then she finally hit send, and the message was delivered instantly.

Lana stared at the little "Delivered" under Charlotte's name. A few seconds passed. Then a response came back quicker than she expected.

Charlotte: girl it is 6:12 in the morning, you are lucky I am up. 4 sure I need me my caffeine. Meet at Oceanside at 8?

Lana let out a small breath, almost a laugh, but it caught in her throat. Her thumb moved to respond before Charlotte sent another message.

Charlotte: you good?

Lana typed back almost instinctively, being asked this question so often these last nine months.

Lana: I'm fine

Charlotte responded immediately once again.

Charlotte: that's a lie. what happened?

Lana swallowed as her eyes flicked to the broken flip phone and the blood on the floor. She didn't know how to type the truth, so she just tiptoed around it.

Lana: Something weird happened last night and I feel like I'm losing my mind.

Three dots appeared. Then vanished. Then reappeared. Charlotte was typing.

Charlotte: okay. first of all. you're not losing your mind. second of all i'm coming there. third of all i need details before i start fighting someone.

Lana let out a relieved sigh, as if the pressure in her chest had been released, and responded.

Lana: I don't want to talk about it over text

Charlotte replied instantly.

Charlotte: good because texting is for losers. i'll be there in 20. imma bring coffee to you instead. ily (:

Lana stared at that message and felt, for the first time all morning, a little bit more secure. She set her phone down and looked back at the broken flip phone sitting on the desk. It looked all innocent now. Just silent and dead. But she knew better. She knew what she heard.

Hello, Lady Bug.

Charlotte knocked exactly once before opening the door, as if she lived there. “Okay,” she said immediately, stepping inside with a paper coffee carrier balanced in one hand and her car keys in the other. “Spill the details. Do I need to beat anyone up or?”

Lana stood near the kitchen counter with her sweatshirt sleeves pulled over her hands and her face as pale as a ghost. Charlotte stopped mid-step as her eyes flicked from Lana’s face to the bandage on her heel, to the faint reddish smudge still visible on the floor near the desk.

“…Okay,” Charlotte said again, more gradually. “What the hell happened?”

Lana opened her mouth to speak, but nothing came out.

Charlotte set the coffee down carefully and switched from Sarcastic Charlotte to Caring Charlotte. “Hey,” she said. “You don’t have to explain it perfectly. Just start somewhere.”

Lana swallowed. “I…” Her voice cracked immediately, even though she had just cleared her throat. “I didn’t sleep.”

Charlotte nodded. “Yeah. That tracks.”

“I thought I was starting to feel normal again,” Lana said. “I saw a little light at the end of my grief tunnel, but now I feel like I lost the light and that I am going backward and I will never feel better.”

Charlotte sympathetically tilted her head. “Okay. Walk me through last night.”

Lana hesitated, eyes drifting to the desk where the broken flip phone sat. Charlotte followed her gaze. “…Is that phone broken?” she asked.

Lana nodded. “I dropped it.”

“Why did you drop it?”

“It rang.”

Charlotte blinked. “Okay. So?”

“At 1:43 in the morning.”

Charlotte didn’t react. She just nodded encouragingly and pushed her to continue her story. “And?”

“And I answered it.” Lana’s hands curled tighter into her sleeves. She was realizing now how crazy everything sounded when she was about to say it out loud. “And someone spoke.”

“Someone you know?”

Lana nodded once.

Charlotte exhaled slowly through her nose. “Okay.”

Lana let out a shaky breath. “It sounded like him.” Charlotte didn’t interrupt. “Not like a stranger who sounded similar to him,” Lana rushed on. “Not like one of those voice-changer things. Charlotte, it was him. It was his voice. I know the way he talks and the way he says my name.”

Charlotte swallowed so hard it could be felt around the whole room.

Lana's voice dropped to almost nothing as a tear started to form at the corner of her eye. "He called me Ladybug."

The room went quiet. So quiet, Lana could have sworn she heard Charlotte's gaze flicker, just for a second, to the flannel on the chair, then back to her.

"How long did the call last?"

"Seconds," Lana said. "Maybe less, I don't know, but long enough."

Charlotte nodded again, thinking hard about her next word choices. "Okay, and then?"

"The phone slipped," Lana said. "I fell, and it broke, and then this morning…" She gestured to the floor. "I stepped on the glass."

Charlotte glanced at the floor. "Hence the crime scene."

Lana gave a weak smile that didn't last long at all. "I checked the call log."

"And?"

"It's not there."

Charlotte's mouth turned into a thin line. "At all?"

"No," Lana said. "Like it never happened."

Charlotte crossed the room and picked up the broken flip phone, turning it over in her hands to investigate the evidence. "And you're sure you weren't dreaming?"

Lana let out a light chuckle. “I wish.”

Charlotte looked at the phone, then at Lana. “Okay. I’m going to ask you something, and I need you to answer honestly.”

Lana nodded.

“Did you take anything last night?” Charlotte said. “Sleeping meds? Wine? Anything?”

“No.”

“Have you been dissociating more than usual? Are you taking the meds your therapist prescribed you?”

“I don’t think so.”

“Have you heard or seen anything else that isn’t there?”

Lana shook her head quickly. “No. This is the only thing. That’s why it’s freaking me out. Why? Do you think I am crazy or something? I’m crazy, aren’t I? I am crazy, and my best friend knows it!”

Charlotte set the phone back down and rested her hand on Lana’s shoulder. “Okay,” she said. “Here’s what we’re not going to do.” Lana looked at her. “We’re not going to jump straight to ‘you’re losing your mind,’ and we’re not going to jump straight to ‘your dead husband is calling you from the void.’”

Lana let out a breath she didn’t realize she’d been holding. “Thank you.”

Charlotte grabbed one of the coffees and shoved it into Lana's hands. "Drink." Then she leaned against the counter again. "Grief does weird things. Especially when you're tired. This was just a one-time thing, and everything is going to be okay."

Lana knew that she was saying that just as much for herself as she was for her, but her eyes still burned as she said, "It felt real."

"I know."

Lana looked up at her and said, "You believe me?"

Charlotte didn't hesitate. "I believe that you experienced something. Yes."

"That's not the same as believing it was him."

"No. It's not."

They stood in silence for a moment. Then Charlotte tilted her head. "What did he say?"

"He didn't say much," Lana said. "Just… my name. The nickname."

"Okay."

"I don't know how to live like this."

"You're not living like this forever. You're just… surviving this part." Lana nodded, tears finally escaping her eyes. Charlotte pulled her into a hug without asking and held her tight. "You don't have to make sense of it today. Okay?"

Lana breathed in Charlotte's familiar perfume, the one she knew her wife got for her. "I'm scared."

"I know," Charlotte said. "But you're not alone, and you're not stupid or weak or crazy." Charlotte squeezed her shoulders once more, reassuringly. "Now. Drink your coffee. Then we'll decide what to do about work."

Lana nodded.

As Charlotte turned away, Lana's gaze drifted back to the broken phone on the desk.

Maybe everything would be okay?

Chapter 4

December 2018

During finals week, the library was alive with the sounds of stressed college students. With the echoes of turning pages, staplers securing important final papers, and the beeping of the vending machine followed by the crisp opening of an energy drink, no one would have ever guessed it was just past one in the morning.

Lana was on about her third Red Bull as she attempted to study for her Calculus final. She sat in the same spot every time she came to the library that semester. She had found her home on the third floor, in a far corner that was snuggled between a window that rattled when the wind was too strong and a towering bookshelf filled with psychology books. She stared down at the textbook in front of her and felt her eyes start to grow heavy. The equations on the paper started to look like some secret code only a cryptographer could crack.

Across the table, David bit into the final chunk of the eraser at the end of his pencil. He had a textbook open and notes scattered around in a messy fan.

“Hungry?” Lana said.

He looked up at Lana and smiled back at her. She loved the way he looked at her. Even when he was stressed, he always looked at her like she was the most interesting thing in the room.

Lana let out a sigh. “Why are you looking at me like that?”

David leaned back in his chair, setting his chewed-up pencil down in order to cross his arms. The wooden chair creaked softly beneath him. He smirked. “Like what?”

“I don’t know… like you like me or something.”

“Is that illegal?”

Lana matched his smirk and looked back down at her paper. “I just don't understand how I got so lucky. You are, well, you. I am just me.”

David’s eyebrows rose. “Just you? No, impossible. You are like the most beautiful painting in a museum.”

She narrowed her eyes. “I think I just threw up a little.”

He tapped his pencil against the table once. “Why do you do that?”

“What?”

David leaned forward, lowering his voice like he was about to tell her the answer to the universe. “You can’t accept the fact that I love you.”

Lana blinked. He’d never said this to her before. Her mouth opened, ready to say it back, but nothing came out.

“Shut up,” she muttered, but the corners of her lips betrayed her serious facade.

“I’m serious,” he said.

Lana rolled her eyes and picked up her pencil again, writing absolutely nothing. She muttered to herself, “I guess I love you too.”

“I’m sorry, can you say that again? I didn’t hear you,” he said with major attitude.

She aimed her pencil at him like a weapon. “You’re supposed to be studying.”

David glanced down at his open textbook and sighed as if it had personally wronged him. “I’ll go back to studying when you say it back.”

“I did.”

“No, you whispered it like a secret.”

Lana couldn’t help it. A laugh slipped out like she’d been trying to keep it locked inside her chest, but David always seemed to find the key anyway. “Fine, I love you, David Johnson.”

David’s eyes softened at the sound. Then he slowly stood up from his chair.

“What are you doing?” Lana said.

He gave her a little smirk, then placed his foot on top of the small wooden chair. He stepped onto the chair and stood, hands cupped around his mouth.

David shouted for all the library to hear, “Did you hear that, everyone? She loves me! Lana Davis loves me!”

The old librarian shushed him and, as red as a tomato, Lana tucked her head onto the table like a turtle hiding away in its shell.

David reached across the table and gently slid her notebook closed.

“Excuse me?” Lana said, snapping her head up.

“You’re done.”

“I am not done. I have one more problem.”

“You are,” he repeated. “You’ve been reading the same sentence for like… fourteen minutes.”

“That’s not even possible.”

David glanced at his phone. “It is when you’ve been doing it since 1:57.”

She hated that he kept track. Not because it was creepy or anything, but because she knew he cared. It was also so nerdy.

David nodded toward her drink, way too warm to even be enjoyable anymore. “Besides, caffeine isn’t working anymore. That’s how I know you’re at the end of your freakishly long battery life.”

Lana’s eyes flicked toward the dark window beside them as if it could hide the sudden warmth in her face. The campus outside was empty. The sidewalks were lit with soft orange lights that made everything look like a movie set. Being with him always made her feel like she was in the movies she used to watch as a kid.

Lana sighed, and her eyes opened just a little more. “Fine. You know you’re cheesy, right?”

David's smile twinkled. "I'm romantic."

"You're annoying."

"I'm devoted."

Lana began to smile even more. "You're delusional."

"Okay, that one might be true," he said back, pointing at her as if he were letting her win.

She shook her head, laughed, and watched David appear to get an idea. His body rotated toward his backpack, seated on a plastic gray chair, and he reached inside. Lana watched curiously as he rummaged around, his fingers searching like he knew exactly where something was but that he was trying to build some level of suspense.

"What are you doing?" she asked.

David didn't answer. He pulled something out carefully and placed it on the table between them.

A mug.

It was small, white, and slightly crooked around the rim. The letters on it were scratched and uneven, like they'd been painted by hand. Lana leaned in to read it.

World's Best Girlfriend.

She blinked. "David…"

He looked suddenly nervous, rubbing the back of his neck like he forgot how to be smooth. “I mean… I couldn’t get any cheesier, so I thought I’d test our limits.”

Lana picked it up, turning it slowly in her hands. The mug was warm, and it wasn’t expensive. Yet, it was the best gift she had ever received.

“This is some sharp cheese right here.”

David shrugged, trying to ignore the horrible joke she just made. “It was either that or a crystal necklace that said ‘Girl Boss,’ and I figured you’d break up with me immediately.”

Lana laughed, but her eyes stung a little. No one ever bought her things like this. She always acted like she didn’t want much, but she was secretly a lover girl; she just needed someone to allow her to be. David, for her, was that person.

“How did I get so lucky?” she said, locking eyes with the perfect man who sat across from her.

He reached across the table and touched her hand, just barely. “You deserve this and every other good thing in your life.”

Lana smiled, grabbed his hand, and left the library filled with slightly more knowledge, but a lot more love than what she came with.

The Second Call

Chapter 5

November 2025

The bedroom sat silent once again. The only sounds that could be heard were the beeping smoke detector and the heater trying to warm the cold apartment.

Lana had barely been able to sleep. All night, her eyes kept drifting, not to the phone or the flashing of that small green light, but across the hall to the small nightlight glowing in the library.

It was her and David's favorite room in the apartment. She was always a romance reader. She just loved the classics. She always liked older things, whether that was older phones, older books, or even older people. She never liked the modern spin on things or futuristic dystopian worlds. She never had a social media account or even Netflix or Hulu on her TV. She just watched classic reruns on cable.

She was never a fantasy reader until she met David. Before bed, he would tell her of the epic journeys of elves and dragons through magical lands filled with mountains and dark caves. She used to find it dorky, but now she wished to know what happened to these characters she would learn about before she fell asleep each night.

She pushed the covers aside and walked carefully to the ivory-colored library, where its warm light seeped into the narrow hallway, beckoning her to enter. She was greeted by the soft glow of fairy lights tracing the golden molding that framed a ceiling painted like the night sky.

The walls were lined with books, some dog-eared and clearly loved, while others were dusty and untouched. The shelves overflowed with fiction, mystery, fantasy, and poetry. Some were his favorites, and most were hers.

Lana sank into the old beanbag nestled in a corner and wrapped herself in a knitted blanket. She rested her head on a large teddy bear and let herself listen, not to silence, but to the sound of time passing.

The antique grandmother clock from David's family, gifted to them as a wedding present, stood tall in the library. It was a piece that had supposedly been in the family for centuries but now sat alone there with her.

The face was cracked in many places, with Roman numerals so faded they seemed more etched than painted. The minute hand moved slowly, as if it were savoring a long journey around the ancient face. The second hand ticked, not like a light click, but like a distant hammer striking iron in a faraway land. As the minute hand crept to point left and the second hand hit the top, a sound sliced through the quiet library like thunder on a clear day.

Ring. Ring.

Lana's heart jumped out of her chest, pounding harder than a striking hammer and faster than a ticking clock. She trembled as she rose from the beanbag and rushed to her old phone sitting face down on the old desk.

The screen flashed "No Caller ID," which, to her, was a silent code that could only mean one thing.

David.

Her hand hovered over the answer button as she was caught in a purgatory between hope and fear. She finally pressed down upon the cold metal key and raised the phone to her ear.

The silence stretched between her and the stranger on the line, only broken by a distant, steady ticking from the grandmother clock. Its ancient hands hovered just past 1:43. She felt as if time stood still.

She swallowed hard before finally gaining the courage to speak.

“Who is this?”

The static hummed through the broken phone, only to be suddenly interrupted by his familiar voice.

“Lana. Don’t take the elevator at work tomorrow. Take the stairs.”

And then, just as suddenly, he was gone. The line went dead.

Chapter 6

October 2020

Some girls grow up dreaming about their wedding day or what their future career may be, but Lana always dreamt of the same thing: her dream apartment. She painted images of a spiral staircase rising to the library of her dreams. She imagined a kitchen decorated as if it were that of a Disney Princess, filled with color, art, and the smell of chocolate chip cookies that would spread to every room. So when Lana stepped into her first apartment, she felt nothing but utter disappointment.

The building itself looked like it had been designed by someone who hated joy. It was tall, beige, and just ehh. The lobby smelled like old carpet and lemon cleaner, a combination that was quite unwelcoming. The fluorescent lights buzzed overhead, and the mailboxes were dented like they'd been punched by a crazy homeless person at one point or another. Which, knowing this neighborhood, wasn't unlikely.

David squeezed her hand as they waited for the elevator, their cardboard boxes stacked beside them. Lana clutched her keyring so tightly the metal left an indent on her palm.

"Well," David said, looking down to meet Lana's gaze, "we are all grown up now, so I guess that's exciting."

"It's not exciting." Lana didn't look at David, but instead stared at the elevator doors. "It's depressing."

David's lips twitched, like he was trying not to laugh at her intensity. "It's a starter apartment."

"It's a prison cell with a view of a dumpster."

David chuckled, "Okay, that's a little dramatic."

Lana rolled her eyes, "David. There is a dumpster outside our window. I saw a rat on the way in. It may have been holding a pizza. Maybe we should add him to the lease, too."

David laughed quietly. "I'm sorry your royal highness expected a penthouse. Looks like the New York City Pizza Rat Monster will have to suffice."

"I didn't expect a penthouse," Lana said, even though she absolutely did. "I expected at least something that didn't smell like a dead hamster."

David lifted a brow. "How often are you smelling dead hamsters, Lana?"

She sighed in defeat as a small smile began to escape, "You know what I mean."

The elevator rang, and the doors slid open with a groan. Its metallic ding sounded as if it was on its last life, trying to take one more breath before tumbling through the Pearly Gates of elevator heaven. Lana stepped in and immediately felt sick; the air inside was too warm and the smell was of old food and possibly more rats. The mirrors were scratched, and the floor mat had a stain that looked like a crime scene. Maybe it was a crime scene. Did someone die here?

David looked down at that mysterious stain and started to smile.

"What are you laughing at?" Lana said in a judgmental tone.

A smirk began to form at the corner of his mouth. “Sorry… I was just thinking that maybe Mr. Pizza Rat spilled his pizza sauce on this carpet, and that's why it looks like bloody murder on the floor.”

Lana couldn’t help but chuckle. Then, looking down at the carpet, she began to feel reality set in. “This is not my dream,” she whispered.

David put his arm around her shoulders. “You’re right.”

Lana blinked at him. “I am?”

He nodded. “This isn’t your dream apartment, but just the place we’re starting off in. And that's okay. We have decades to wait.”

The elevator jolted upward as Lana swallowed hard. Her throat suddenly felt tight with something she hadn’t expected. An overwhelming amount of fear.

The truth was, Lana wasn’t scared of the apartment itself, but of what it meant. Growing up, she never felt like she had a proper home. The house she grew up in never felt like hers, especially after her father died. It felt like a hotel in which her mother would have a new guest at least once a week. Some stayed longer, but she never committed to any of them. Even in high school, even when she had friends and grew closer to her mother and brother, she still always felt like she couldn’t fully let anyone in.

And now, she wasn’t just living with family because she was forced to; she was moving in with someone voluntarily. Someone she loved more than she ever thought she was capable of

loving. For the first time in her life, this was something permanent. It was easier to complain about the building and much harder to admit she was terrified of this newfound stability.

The elevator dinged again, and the doors opened on the sixth floor. The hallway was narrow and dim, lined with doors that all looked identical. The carpet was a dull brown, worn thin in places for God knows what reason. She could already hear an argument occurring from within an apartment a couple of doors down the hallway.

David grabbed the first box. “Alright. Unit 612.” Lana followed him, her box lighter than his. When they reached the door, David dug for the key and glanced back at her. “You ready?”

Lana stared at the peeling paint on the doorframe and imagined her dream apartment. The spiral staircase, the library, the sunlight pouring through beautiful stained-glass windows that made the whole room feel like a coloring book. She imagined a kitchen that smelled like chocolate chip cookies and a countertop made of the most beautiful marble. She looked now at the chipped brass number on the door.

612

He opened the door, and inside was so much worse.

The apartment was small. Not cozy small, but a tight small. The ceilings were low, and the carpet was an ugly gray that looked like it had once been white before someone gave up trying to clean it anymore. The walls were beige. Just beige. The kitchen was shoved into a corner with cabinets that didn’t quite close and a stove that looked older than both of them combined.

Lana walked in slowly, turning in a full circle like she was witnessing a crime scene or was about to take her last hamster-smelling breath.

“This is… just ehhh,” Lana said with disgust on her face.

David laughed and set his box down. “Okay, but look.” He pointed toward the living room window. “Natural light.” Lana followed his gaze. The window was small, but it let in sunlight. Dust floated in it like tiny planets. Outside, the trees were turning orange and gold, and the street below looked alive with couples laughing and children selling lemonade at their homemade stand.

She sighed. “It’s still a prison cell.”

David crossed the room and pulled open the blinds, letting more light in. “It’s not a prison cell. It’s a blank canvas.”

“A blank canvas?”

He nodded, eyes seeming to sparkle with all the potential he saw in the apartment,“We can make it ours.” That sentence hit her harder than it should’ve.

Ours.

Lana looked down at the carpet and the chipped baseboards. And somehow her chest still tightened because she wanted that.

She wanted it to be *ours.*

She set her box down carefully as David began wandering around. He opened doors like an excited golden retriever looking for a tennis ball. “Oooh, closet!” he announced, yanking it open. The closet door squealed, and inside was an empty rod and a single sad hanger. David nodded approvingly. “Solid closet.”

Lana stared. “It’s a hole in the wall.”

David kept exploring. “Bathroom!” He pushed the bathroom door open. The shower curtain was already hung and decorated with tiny seashells that looked like they’d been printed in the twentieth century. The sink was stained, and the mirror was slightly warped, making his reflection stretch like one at a carnival.

David turned back to Lana. “It’s got character.”

She examined the weathered curtain. “It’s got mold, more likely.”

David laughed again and moved toward the bedroom. “Lana,” he called. “Come here.”

She followed, ever so reluctantly, and stepped into the bedroom. The room was smaller than she had thought was even possible. It would fit the bed frame they’d brought, and not much else. There was barely enough room to walk around it. The one window faced the building next door, offering a beautiful view of brick.

David watched her face carefully and could see the disappointment in her eyes. He stepped closer and lowered his voice to calm her down. “Hey.”

Lana forced herself to look at him. “It’s fine.”

David's eyes softened. "That's a lie. I didn't even ask you."

"It's just…" she started, but then stopped. Because she couldn't say that she thought it would be perfect and that she was scared of what was to come. The unknowns that were to come. Instead, she used humor, the armor she'd always resorted to wearing. "I just feel like… I feel very claustrophobic. I think if I scream too loud, the walls might just cave in on me."

David smiled and softly bit his lip. "Then we'll scream quietly." He set his hands on her shoulders. "Lana. Look at me."

As she did, his expression changed from something flirtatious to something more caring. "This place isn't forever," he said. "But you know what is?"

Lana knew what he was going to say, but still replied. "What?"

David lifted a hand, brushing a loose strand of hair behind her ear. "Us." He leaned away from the wall and walked over to grab another box. He continued to speak. "You're thinking too hard. You're trying to make this mean something bad."

"That's not true."

"Yes, you are. You're always waiting for the floor to fall out from under you." Lana looked away quickly. "But I'm not leaving." That sentence was so simple, but it meant a lot to her at that very moment.

David stepped back and clapped his hands once, as if he were a director saying “cut” on a scene and deciding to completely switch the topic of conversation. “Okay,” he announced. “Plan.”

“Plan?”

David pointed toward the living room. “Let's start small. Make it magical.”

Lana let out a weak laugh. “How?”

David’s grin turned absolutely feral. “Pinterest.”

“Pinterest?”

“Yes,” David said confidently, as if he’d just solved world hunger. “We are going to become the kind of people who have”—he put up jazz hands and sang—“throw pillows.” Lana chuckled. He continued, “The kind of people who have a plant that doesn’t die in a day.”

“David,” Lana interrupted, “we have forty dollars and a pack of ramen.”

“Okay. We are going to become the kind of people who have one throw pillow.”

Lana snorted, and not in an attractive way. She rolled her eyes. “Shut up.”

“Not until you admit you’re excited.”

“I’m not excited.”

“You’re a little excited.”

“I’m anxious.”

“That’s just excitement with trauma,” David said casually.

Lana thought for a moment, then admitted, “That is… unfortunately accurate.”

David beamed like he’d said the smartest thing ever. “Thank you.” He grabbed his phone and started scrolling. “Okay, okay. First, we need to be creative and imagine the space as we want it.”

Lana crossed her arms and looked at the dullness around her. “The space is beige. How are you going to fix that, Mr. Pinterest Interior Designer Guy?”

David ignored her and paced the apartment. “Even the best books started as just a piece of paper. Gotta start somewhere.” Then he stopped in the middle of the living room and looked at her like he’d just remembered something important.

“Wait.”

Lana blinked. “What?”

David dug into his backpack and pulled out a tiny string of fairy lights still wrapped up in plastic. “These should do.”

“Do? For what?”

“For this,” he said, gesturing around like he was presenting a great gift. “For our blank canvas.” He walked over and pressed the lights into her hands, warm from being tucked in his bag.

“I thought,” he said carefully, “if you can’t have your spiral staircase yet… we can at least have stars.” Lana stared down at the lights as if they might just make her melt into his arms.

She hated how easily he could make her smile. David took her chin gently in his hands and forced her to look into his eyes. “I know you are nervous, and this is a big step for us. But just know that I am here for you, and we can do this.”

Lana’s eyes finally overflowed. Tears dripped down her cheeks, but David didn’t flinch. He just pulled her into his arms. Lana pressed her face into his flannel, because of course he was wearing flannel, and laughed wetly through her tears.

“You’re wearing that stupid shirt again,” she mumbled.

David kissed the top of her head. “It’s my emotional support flannel.”

“You’re insane.”

“You love it.”

Lana hesitated for a moment, then whispered with such a sigh, “Yeah.”

David pulled back slightly to look at her. “Yeah?”

Lana nodded, wiping her cheeks with the sleeve of her sweater. “Yeah.”

David’s grin returned, bright and boyish. “Okay. Then let’s do this.”

Lana blinked. “Do what?”

He pointed dramatically toward the ceiling. “We hang the stars and then maybe put on a little show for those perverted rats under them.”

Lana shoved him away in disgust, even though she knew damn well she would be participating in whatever show David wanted to put on that night.

They didn’t have a ladder, so David stood on a chair that looked like it might collapse at any moment. Lana stood a couple feet behind him, holding the knotted ball of lights. She knew she would be no help if he fell and felt it would be better to just try and not hurt the both of them.

“This is so unsafe,” Lana said, watching him wobble.

David scoffed. “I am an athlete.” He taped lights to the ceiling with one hand and balanced them with the other.

“You played intramural basketball twice.”

“And I dominated,” he insisted.

Lana rolled her eyes and reached up, steadying his waist. He finished taping the lights and hopped down.

“Moment of truth,” he announced, plugging them in as if he were Clark from Christmas Vacation.

The lights flickered once. Then, at the same time, both Lana and David said, “Wow.”

Warm golden dots bloomed along the ceiling like tiny suns. The apartment was still small and beige with a smell of rats and mold.

But now it had stars!

David stepped beside her, brushing her shoulder to make her aware of his presence. “See?”

“Wow, I love it.”

David gasped. “Did Lana Davis just compliment this dumpster apartment?”

Lana shoved him. “Don’t ruin it.”

David laughed, then turned serious again, stepping behind her and wrapping his arms around her waist. He rested his chin on her shoulder, both of them staring at the lights.

“You know,” he murmured, “We don’t need a spiral staircase to have a library.”

Lana blinked. “We don’t?”

David nodded toward the bare wall. “We build shelves and fill them up. We can even make a little corner for reading in the laundry room.”

Lana smiled at the idea and could already imagine it, “You really think we can make this feel like home?”

David kissed her forehead. “I already do.”

She never thought she would think this about a ‘dumpster apartment’. But in that moment, with his arms around her and the fairy lights above them, it felt possible.

David’s voice dropped even quieter. “Promise me something.”

Lana gazed up at him. “What?”

“Promise me,” he said, “That even when things get hard… you’ll let yourself be happy anyway.”

Lana’s stomach twisted. “David…”

“I’m serious,” he said, still gentle but firm. “You deserve it. You deserve to live in the good moments when they happen instead of waiting for them to disappear. Like right now. One day, those lights will wear out, and we won’t have stars anymore. But look at us enjoying them now. And, when the lights due die, I have Amazon Prime, so they will be back up in no time.”

Lana chuckled and stared back up at the lights. Unbeknownst to her, David stepped away from her to put on some music from his little, worn-out speaker he won in a game during orientation week. Frank Sinatra’s voice filled the starlit room and, at that very moment, it changed into a ballroom. David grabbed Lana by the waist and pulled her close. She laughed, surprised by it, and David’s eyes lit up.

“There she is,” Lana swore it was his favorite line in the world.

“You’re so cheesy.”

“I’m romantic.”

“You’re delusional.”

David pointed at her. “That one might be true.”

Lana laughed again, and for a moment, just a moment, the future didn’t feel like something she had to fear. It felt like something they could step into. Together.

Chapter 7

November 2025

The clicking of Lana's dark wedges echoed through the hallways of her office building. All morning, her mind had been lost in thoughts about last night's phone call. Lana had always been a dedicated and hardworking employee. She loved her job as a lead engineer at one of the state's largest firms. After the accident, her boss pushed her to take some time off, but she didn't want to. She enjoyed her job. Designing bridges wasn't a burden; it was a privilege. It was the one place in her life where everything still had rules. If something failed, it wasn't because the universe was out to get her or because her life was falling apart; it was because a calculation was wrong. These were all problems that were fixable and not confusing.

But today was different. She couldn't shake that uneasy feeling nesting deep within her chest. Questions filled her mind:

How could last night be real? Who would try and play such a trick on me?

The thought of someone pretending to be this voice that she yearned to hear again. But deep down, Lana knew it wasn't a prank. David had been gone for nine months. His life was taken by a reckless teenager in a hit-and-run, yet his voice spoke to her through that phone.

Her fingers tightened around the strap of her work bag as she passed familiar faces. Coworkers smiled at her the way they always did now. They were never normal, but always hesitant. Like they were all aware she was glass, and no one wanted to be the one to knock her off a table.

“Morning, Lana,” someone said to her in an endearing tone

“Hey,” she answered.

Her computer sat waiting in her office. Her email notifications blinked as if they were asking to be read. Before she could even take her seat, her phone buzzed with a reminder in her pocket.

11:30 AM - Meeting with Richard Halden

Richard Halden was her boss. He didn’t call meetings for no reason. He was the kind of man who wore a tie even when the rest of the office went business casual. The kind of man who always looked like he had somewhere else to be.

He was not a “let’s just chat” boss. No. This was definitely something important. As she reached the doors of her boss’s office, the reality of her situation began to set in. Her boss never called her in for meetings, especially in the middle of the week. She wasn’t in the midst of a big project and definitely wasn't producing work that would result in her receiving a promotion, so this was most likely nothing good.

She knocked on the door with two light knocks that sounded just about as confident as she felt walking into this meeting.

“Come in,” he hollered.

Lana stepped inside. His office was exactly what she had expected working for him for the last four years. It was clean and organized with gray carpet and dark leather chairs. There were framed certifications on the wall and a thick binder sitting neatly on the desk.

Richard looked up from his laptop, and for a second, Lana thought she saw something like worry on his face. Or maybe it was just discomfort. People didn't know what to do with grief. Even bosses.

"Hey," Richard said, standing up. "Close the door, please."

Lana did and then stood there for a moment, unsure if she should sit. Richard gestured to the chair in front of his desk.

Lana sat, resting her work bag next to her. Her knee bounced once under the table before she forced it still. Richard took a breath like he was choosing his words carefully. "How are you doing?" he asked.

Lana blinked. She was so sick of answering this question recently that her response became automatic rather than genuine. "I'm okay."

Richard nodded, but his expression didn't change. "That's what you always say."

Lana gulped in response.

He leaned back in his chair, folding his hands together. "Lana, I want to start by saying we care about you here. Truly. You've been one of the strongest engineers on my team since the day you walked into this firm."

Her chest tightened at the word strong. Strong used to mean something. She was strong, being the only woman to graduate with a Civil degree that semester. Strong was getting through a hard workout or going through all of middle and high school without a father. But now, it meant nothing. Strong meant she cried in the shower instead of in public. Strong meant she smiled during meetings and screamed in her car afterward. Strong meant she lived because who else would check on her elderly neighbor? Richard continued. “I know what happened to…” he paused as if the name was forbidden. “...David. It shook your entire world, and I don’t expect you to be over it. I don’t think anyone could be.”

Lana’s throat burned. She nodded once. “But,” Richard added, and Lana felt the word hit her like a truck. “We need to talk about your work.”

There it was. Lana’s fingers curled tightly in her lap as Richard slid a folder across the desk. Lana didn’t open it yet. She didn’t need to because she already knew the work she had been submitting.

“I’ve been reviewing your last few submissions,” he said. “The stormwater calcs weren’t consistent. The load estimates on the east wing of the apartment on Delaware Street were incomplete. The revision set you sent last week… didn’t even match the previous markup.”

Lana stared at the folder as if, if she looked at it long enough, it might just explode. “I’m sorry,” she whispered.

Richard sighed softly. Not annoyed, just tired and concerned. “I know you’re trying,” he said. “But you’re not here. Well, not fully, and that’s dangerous in this line of work.”

Lana knew what he meant. Bridges could not forgive her mistakes, buildings didn't care if she was grieving, and concrete didn't soften just because her heart was still broken. But still, hearing it out loud made her feel sick. Dangerous.

"I don't want to lose you," Richard said. "But I also can't keep assigning you as a lead review if I can't trust the output."

Lana's eyes flicked up. "So, what are you saying?"

Richard paused. "I'm saying I want you to take some time."

Lana's chest tightened. "No."

He blinked. "Lana…"

"I can't," she said quickly. Too quickly. "I can't go home and just sit there. I'll go insane."

Richard's expression softened again, and Lana hated that she could see the sympathy in it. She hated being pitied more than anything.

"I understand," he said. "But you're already suffering, and your work is suffering, and I'm just trying to keep you safe." Richard rubbed his forehead. "Look. We have deadlines. Some big ones too, and you know clients are impatient. I can give you lighter tasks and smaller loads. Like printing and document review. You know, things that don't put full project weight on your shoulders."

Lana nodded slowly. It felt like a demotion, even though she knew it wasn't meant to, and it felt like a failure.

Richard leaned forward slightly. "But I need something from you, too."

Lana swallowed. "What?"

"I need you to be honest with me," he said. "If you can't work, you can't work. And that's okay, but I can't keep getting surprised."

She blinked fast and nodded again. "I understand."

"I'm not mad at you, Lana. I'm worried about you."

Honestly, anger would have been easier. She could handle anger, but worry felt like a hand on an open wound, and she would almost rather just bleed out.

Lana stood slowly. "I'm sorry," she whispered again.

Richard shook his head. "Don't apologize. Just… take care of yourself. Okay?"

Lana nodded, then turned toward the door before being interrupted one last time. "And Lana?"

She paused, her hand already resting on the cold doorknob, and turned to face Richard.

"If you need help, please ask. You don't have to do this alone."

Lana gave a polite nod, then quietly excused herself from the office.

The hallway felt longer now, and the office felt louder. Back at her desk, Lana sat down and stared at her screen. A spreadsheet was open.

It should've helped. She was overwhelmed with the workload. But all she could hear was Richard's voice.

You're not here. Not fully.

He was right. She wasn't fully here because part of her was still in her apartment. Part of her was kneeling down on the hardwood floor, holding a broken phone.

She forced herself to work anyway and pulled up project files to pretend she was normal. She answered emails, reviewed drawings, and clicked through tabs. But she moved more slowly than usual as her thoughts tripped over each other.

By the time lunch ended, Lana felt worn out. She needed a simple, small task that she could do without thinking.

Printing.

She always printed hard copies before reviews. She liked holding paper because it made the work feel more real. So she gathered the plan set, slid it into her folder, and headed toward the print room.

As she reached the elevator doors, she hovered over the call button and paused. She felt like she was missing something. Her hand patted her pockets, then her bag, and even checked her ears. But no. She forgot her earbuds.

A sigh escaped from her lips. She always listened to classical music on her way to the print room. She felt that it made the mundane task feel somewhat romantic. As if she were a pretty princess printing magical blueprints in her fairy-tale castle.

She turned around to head back to her office, frustrated by yet another delay in the work she wanted to get done.

When she returned, she slipped the earbuds into her ears and played her favorite Ophelia Wilde album: A Concert for My Soulmate. She pressed the elevator button and waited.

And waited.

The light blinked, but the doors stayed closed.

She stared at the metal seams, her breath slowing, and her heart sank at an eerie realization.

Don't take the elevator.

Lana’s stomach twisted at the thought of last night’s phone call. She pulled one earbud out, and the noises around her pulled her out of her fairytale. She stepped closer to the elevator doors and pressed the call button again. The light blinked, but nothing happened.

Lana’s throat went dry. The warning replayed in her head.

She looked around, pretending she was calm. Pretending she was just waiting like everyone else and not hearing a dead man’s voice. One coworker walked past, not paying attention, while another stood nearby on their phone, laughing at their screen.

She took the elevator that morning, and she was fine, but maybe she shouldn't have. Lana backed away from the elevator slowly and approached the dimly lit stairwell. The door creaked as she opened it. She began her descent down the five flights of stairs, one at a time, and her usually calming music somehow began to feel like the background of some suspenseful film. Each note only made that pounding in her chest stronger.

She tried to breathe normally. Tried to tell herself she was being dramatic and that this didn't mean anything, but halfway down the stairs, she heard it.

CRASH.

A crash thundered so loudly, echoing through the stairwell like a bomb had gone off. The rattling of the railing stopped her in her tracks.

Lana froze. Her earbuds were still playing, but the music felt miles away now, like it was happening in another world. She pressed her hand to the rail; the metal vibrated faintly beneath her palm. Then another sound followed.

A mass of people. They were shouting, screaming, and crying. It sounded so panicked that it made Lana's blood turn to ice.

She started moving faster, her heels striking the stairs louder and less controlled than before. She gripped the railing, her heart beating so hard her mouth began to taste like metal.

By the time she reached the bottom floor, glowing red and blue lights shone through the small window of the iron door. As she entered the lobby, she saw a crowd of worried faces.

Some cried. Some looked away. Some grabbed their cell phones to capture the disturbing moment unfolding before them.

Lana stepped forward like she wasn't fully in her body. Like she was watching a scene from above. And then she saw it.

Mangled metal weaved around lifeless bodies. According to what she heard around her, three lives were lost, all within the elevator shaft. And she stood there alive.

Her mouth opened, but no sound came out. Her hands shook, and her knees nearly buckled. But she somehow stayed standing, the shock holding her upright.

The elevator doors were bent, and the metal frame twisted. There were papers scattered across the floor, drifting like dead leaves. Someone's badge lay facedown near a smear of blood. Someone's shoe sat by itself.

And in the middle of it all, Lana could only think one thing:

That could have been me.

The air smelled like burnt wiring, and someone behind her sobbed loudly. Lana couldn't move. She couldn't blink. Her ears rang through the noises of someone else whispering, "Oh my God… oh my God…"

For the first time in nine months, Lana didn't feel grief or sadness. She didn't even feel disbelief. She felt something entirely different.

Lana was afraid, and what she was feeling was fear. Because if David could warn her… that meant David was still somewhere.

Chapter 8

May 2024

“I can't look, what if it’s positive?”

Charlotte snatched Lana’s hand from her side and grasped it firmly. “Then it's a miracle, and we will figure it out.”

Lana gave Charlotte a not-so-reassuring smile and said, “Okay, I’m going to look.” She began to turn over the white plastic pregnancy test she got at CVS just hours before, but before she could see the results, she threw it into the sink in front of her and looked away. “Charlotte, I can't! You look first.”

Lana and David were by no means trying to have a baby. Lana was always against going on the pill because she always felt like it messed with her emotions and made her feel “like life wasn’t real.” But they always used protection. Well. Almost always. So when Lana was two weeks late, she had a hunch something was wrong.

Charlotte dropped Lana's hand to grab the test from the sink. She let out a deep sigh. “How about we look together, on the count of three, okay?”

“Okay.”

Both girls grabbed onto this little two-dollar stick that seemed to hold all the answers to the universe and began to count.

“One.”

“Two.”

“Three.”

Charlotte flipped the stick over, and both girls became dead silent.

Positive.

“Holy shit,” Charlotte said. “I really didn’t think it would be positive.”

“Neither did I.” Lana's eyes started to burn and then welled up. “What am I going to do? I’m not even married yet!”

Charlotte didn’t panic. That’s what Lana loved about her. Charlotte never panicked. Not when her car broke down on I-95. Not when her first roommate tried to make tuna in the microwave every evening before bed. Not even when Lana called her crying at 2 a.m., thinking she had failed her Calculus final. And Charlotte actually did fail that Calculus final.

“Well, first of all, when has following traditional values ever been something you do? And secondly, we will figure this out! Everything happens for a reason.”

Lana sniffled and wiped her cheeks with the sleeve of her sweatshirt. She knew she’d probably wear this same sweatshirt for the next three days, especially since her entire life had just been flipped over by a CVS stick.

Lana nodded quickly, tears still falling. “I don’t want to mess this up.”

“You won’t,” Charlotte said. “You’re literally incapable of not caring.”

That only made Lana cry harder. Charlotte stepped forward and pulled her into a hug. A Charlotte hug. She loved nothing more.

Lana pressed her face into Charlotte’s shoulder and whispered, “David is going to freak out.”

“David is going to cry.”

Lana blinked. “No, he won’t.”

Charlotte stared at her like she was stupid. “He cried when the dog in the movie died last week.”

Lana tried to keep a serious face, but then a laugh managed to creep its way out. Then reality hit her again. She looked back down at the test.

Positive.

She wasn’t ready for this, to be a mom. She felt that being a mom was for someone older who owned a house with a backyard and a kitchen. Someone who wore matching pajamas and drank from cups made of glass, not plastic. Not a girl who still had ramen noodles in her cabinet and student debt.

Lana’s hands flew to her stomach. Nothing felt different. She didn’t feel pregnant or glowing or motherly. She just felt terrified.

“What if I’m not ready?” Lana whimpered.

Charlotte's voice softened. "No one is ready. Literally no one. People just pretend that they are."

Lana laughed again, wiping her nose. "That's comforting."

Charlotte smirked. "I know. I'm basically a therapist."

Lana stared at the test again. "What if I lose it?"

Charlotte's expression changed immediately. That was not something she could joke about this time.

"Hey," Charlotte said quietly. "Don't do that to yourself."

Lana swallowed hard. "I'm just saying…"

Charlotte stepped closer again, her hands finding Lana's arms. "Listen to me. You are allowed to be excited. Even if you're scared or it's early. Also, can you see how it is positive? You've got to be that, too. You have to be positive."

Lana had always been the kind of girl who didn't get her hopes up because if she never got too excited, then she couldn't be too disappointed. She thought excitement gave things the power to hurt you. She whispered, "Okay."

Charlotte squeezed her gently. "Okay." And then backed away.

"So," Charlotte said, "how are you gonna tell him?"

"I don't know," Lana admitted.

“You have to tell him, Lana.”

“I know I have to tell him. I just... I... I don’t know how. I didn’t plan this. None of this was planned. It’s just… happening.”

Charlotte nodded slowly. “Okay. Breathe.”

Lana inhaled shakily and took one deep breath in… and out.

“David loves you and is obsessed with you. He’s going to be shocked, yes, but he’s not going to be mad.”

Lana whispered, “What if he thinks I’m irresponsible?”

Charlotte snorted. “He’s the one who ‘almost always’ used protection. If anyone is irresponsible, it’s him.”

Lana’s mouth dropped open. “Charlotte!”

Charlotte shrugged as if she were completely innocent. “I’m just saying.”

“What if he leaves?”

Charlotte’s face went deadly serious. “He won’t.”

Lana whispered, “You don’t know that.”

Charlotte leaned in close. “I do. David will not leave. He’s already stayed through everything. Your moods, your weird little habits, and even when you made him play Mario Kart until 3 a.m. just so you could win for the first time.”

Lana winced. “Okay… It's a lot harder than it looks.” She wiped her face again.

Charlotte grabbed the test and shoved it into the little CVS bag. “I have just the way we can tell him.”

Lana blinked. “What?”

Charlotte grabbed Lana’s wrist. “Come on.”

Lana stumbled slightly as Charlotte pulled her out of the apartment, down the hallway, and into the sunlight outside.

Charlotte turned on the blinker in her 2012 Mini Cooper, which smelled of lemons and had enough legroom for anyone under the height of roughly 5'6”. Lana sat in the passenger seat, tapping her leg about twenty million times a second and fidgeting with her hands.

“What are we doing?” Lana asked.

Charlotte didn’t slow down. “We’re going to the park near campus.”

“The park?”

“Yes,” Charlotte said. “David used to always go there when he was stressed in college. He liked sitting near the water because he thought it was ‘cinematic.’”

Lana always loved the fact that Charlotte and David were so close. She never felt jealous or worried that they were anything more than friends. Well, mostly because Charlotte preferred women over men a million to one, and David didn’t seem interested in the idea of a lavender marriage.

Charlotte glanced at Lana. “Text him. Tell him to meet you there.”

Lana nodded and began to type:

Lana: Can you meet me at the park? I need to tell you something.

She stared at the message. Charlotte watched her like a hawk. “Send it.”

“What if he thinks I’m breaking up with him?”

“Then he’ll run there faster.”

Lana pressed send. Instantly, three dots appeared. David was typing.

David: Are you okay? I’m coming right now.

Lana stared at the screen. He didn’t ask why or hesitate; he was just ready to be there for her. She swallowed hard and shoved her phone in her pocket. “Okay.”

Charlotte nodded. “Okay.”

They pulled into the first open spot in the parking lot across the street from the park. It was peaceful, birds chirping, water flowing, all that jazz. The sunlight painted everything gold like it was a romantic scene, but Lana felt like she was going to throw up, which didn't really fit that theme.

Lana stood by the bench near the water, her hands clenched together in front of her. Charlotte stood slightly behind her, arms crossed, keeping watch like the lesbian version of Paul Blart.

Lana's chest rose and fell too fast. She kept turning around at any noise she heard, only to be disappointed every time it wasn't David. Until, what felt like a hundred false alarms later, there he was.

His hair was messy like he'd run his hands through it a hundred times. His shirt was slightly wrinkled, and his eyes were full of so much concern she could have sworn they were glowing.

"Lana?" he said, breathless. "What's wrong?"

Lana's throat tightened immediately. Seeing him made the panic worse and better at the same time. He reached her and gently grabbed her hands. "Talk to me. What's up?"

Lana tried. She really did. But no words came out. She felt like a broken toy. Like one of those toys where you press their hand and it belts out a song or something.

David's eyes searched her face. "Did something happen? Are you hurt?" She shook her head quickly. He exhaled like he was relieved. "Okay. Okay. Then what is it?"

Lana swallowed hard, her eyes burning again. Her hands trembled in his, then her voice finally came back to life. "I'm late."

David froze. He blinked once. "Late… like? What do you mean late?"

Lana nodded, tears covering the surface of her cheeks. “Like… that kind of late.”

David stared at her, confused, and then Lana saw in his eyes the moment he realized what she meant. God, she felt like it took him three to five business days to connect the dots, but he finally did.

“Are you sure?” he asked.

Lana nodded again, pulling the CVS bag out of her pocket with shaking fingers. “We took a test.”

David’s eyes dropped to the bag. He handled it with so much care. His hands looked as if they were too big to handle something that small. He pulled the test out and stared at it.

Positive.

David’s eyes widened, and then his mouth parted. Lana watched him try to say something. She wanted him to say something. Literally anything would have been great.

“What,” Lana finally buckled, “what are you thinking?”

David’s lips trembled just barely. “I’m thinking,” he said softly, “that you’re gonna be a mom.”

Lana let out a shaky sob. “I’m not ready.”

David stepped forward and pulled her into him, pressing her forehead against his chest. “I’m not ready either,” he whispered. “But… we’ll be okay.” Lana cried harder, and she clung to

him. His arms tightened around her. “Lana,” he said, his voice shaking now, “Lana, I love you so much.”

“I love you,” Lana choked out.

David pulled back just enough to look at her. His hands moved to her face to let his thumbs wipe her tears away. “You’re not alone,” he whispered. “Okay? You’re not doing this alone.”

Lana nodded through the tears. David looked down at her stomach. His hand hovered, but he didn’t touch her yet. It was like he was asking permission without words. Lana nodded her approval, and David’s palm rested gently against her stomach, so softly and carefully. “Oh my God,” he whispered.

Charlotte, behind them, sniffled loudly. “OMG, I’m so happy for you guys!”

David glanced over and blinked as if he had just noticed her. “Are you crying?”

Charlotte wiped her face aggressively. “No.”

David started to smirk. “Yes, you are.”

“Shut up.”

Lana laughed through tears. “And you said he would cry. What a hypocrite.”

Charlotte then left to give them some space.

Lana leaned into David once again and whispered, “Promise me you won’t leave.”

David froze as if she had asked the stupidest question known to mankind. Then he pulled back, looking her dead in the eyes. “I’m not going anywhere,” he said very firmly. “Not ever. Okay? I’m right here.”

Lana nodded, tears falling again.

“We’re keeping it,” David said softly, looking back at Lana. “Right?”

Lana hesitated. Then nodded. She had thought about it. Ending it. She had thought about how much easier it would have been. But she knew she couldn't hide that from David. And how could she ever end something that was him? How could she ever say goodbye to even that little part of him?

“Okay,” he whispered against her hair. “Okay. We’re keeping it.”

Lana smiled, wiping her face. For the first time since she saw the positive test, the fear loosened its grip a little. Because David was here

The Third Call

Chapter 9

November 2025

The rain hadn't stopped for hours, and it wasn't a peaceful type of rain either. Sometimes rain is so calming that it lets you cuddle up with a good book, but today it just sounded like the end of a tragic movie.

Lana sat curled up on her bed with a knitted blanket wrapped around her shoulders and a mug nestled snugly in both hands. Charlotte paced around the room with soaking wet hair and socks so drenched they left little footprints on the floor every time she stepped. She took a bite of one of the chocolate cookies she had made in Lana's kitchen. Her chewing sounded aggressive.

"You know I love you, Lana," Charlotte said with a mouth full of cookies, still pacing. "And I have stood by you through every new hobby, wild theory, and strange thing you've clung to since David died."

Lana didn't look at her. She just stared at her tea.

Charlotte stopped walking and pointed at Lana with the cookie in her hand. "But this," she said, her voice sharper now, "this is insane."

Lana swallowed. "I know."

Charlotte blinked and rolled her eyes. "No, you don't know. You think you know, but you just don't because if you knew how insane it sounded, then you would not be sitting here saying it like it's completely normal."

"Char…"

"No. I'm sorry. I'm not trying to be mean. I'm just…" She stopped and brought her fingers to her forehead. "I'm tired."

This wasn't the first time Charlotte had to deal with Lana after the accident. Actually, this was probably over the hundredth time she had to deal with her. The first time was the night it happened, when Lana called her and couldn't even speak into the phone. Charlotte drove there so fast that she ran two red lights. She barely remembered walking into the hospital with all the hell she had to see Lana go through that night.

Since then, she felt that Lana came in waves. Some days, her grief was quiet, and she acted almost completely normal. On those days, Charlotte would let herself believe, for a second, that maybe the worst of it had passed. Then there were nights like tonight, where Lana would look at her with those hollow eyes and say something just insane. Charlotte had to talk her down from the edge so many times, but she always came back. She was always there through the panic attacks, the sudden crying in grocery store aisles, the mornings Lana couldn't get out of bed, and the nights she couldn't fall asleep. She stayed even when Lana pushed her away. She stayed for the days that Lana swore she was fine, even when Charlotte knew she was lying because Charlotte knew Lana better than Lana knew herself. And the worst part was, Lana didn't just lose David; Charlotte did too.

David was one of her best friends, the kind who annoyed the hell out of her, but she loved him like a brother. He was the only person who could make Lana laugh when Lana didn't want to laugh, and the only person who could match Charlotte's sarcasm. But Charlotte didn't really

get time to grieve for him. Well, not properly, because Lana was falling apart, and someone had to be the strong one and hold her together.

Lana finally looked up. “You’re tired?”

Charlotte gave her a look. “Yes, Lana. I’m tired. You have been living in a depressive spiral for nine months, and I feel like all I do is support you. You need to try! You need to try to do at least something to change how you feel. You can’t keep putting this on me. I love you so much, but I can’t keep doing this. I can’t keep being this support system all the time. It's exhausting. I have a wife! I have kids! I can’t just keep coming over here every time anything happens.”

Lana knew she had been a lot on Charlotte, and to hear her say it out loud was painful. But she could also see how much weight was lifted off her shoulders when she did so. That's what inspired her to tell Charlotte the next part of her story.

Lana whispered, “He told me not to take the elevator.”

Charlotte just looked down at the ground and stopped pacing.

“And then… it crashed. And those people…” Her voice cracked. “They’re dead.”

Charlotte’s eyes grew glossy instantly, shocking Lana, because Charlotte hadn’t cried to her since the funeral. She just blinked hard and shook her head like she could shake the emotion out. “I... I don’t even know what you are talking about, Lana. A crash in an elevator, what?”

Lana swallowed. “That could’ve been me.”

Charlotte looked at her like she wanted to argue, but she couldn't. She said, "Lana."

Lana whispered, "I know his voice."

Charlotte shut her eyes. That was the first sign Charlotte was actually cracking. Because she always had something to say. Whether it was sarcastic or logical, it was at least something that could attempt to fix things.

Lana leaned forward, her voice getting faster like she was trying to convince Charlotte before Charlotte could stop her. "I know his voice. I know it like I know my own. Like I know how you say 'literally' before every sentence."

"I don't."

"I'm not… I'm just saying I know him. I know him, Char."

Charlotte's jaw tightened. "Okay."

Lana blinked. "Okay?"

Charlotte exhaled slowly. "Okay. You think you heard him."

"I don't think."

"Lana, I am trying so hard not to freak out right now," Charlotte snapped. "I can't do this," she whispered, mostly to herself.

Lana's mouth opened a little in shock. "What do you mean you can't?"

Charlotte spun around. “I mean, I can’t have this conversation. I can’t have a conversation where my best friend is telling me her dead husband is calling her. Like, what am I supposed to say?”

Lana swallowed. “That you believe me.”

“I don’t believe you.”

“You don’t?”

Charlotte pointed at her aggressively. “I believe that you believe it. I believe you heard something and aren’t lying. Lana, you don’t even lie about small things. You would confess to murder if someone asked you if you took their Diet Coke.”

“Then why are you acting like I’m crazy?”

Charlotte’s voice rose immediately. “Because what you’re saying is crazy!”

Lana flinched. Charlotte instantly regretted it. She sighed and rubbed her forehead again. “I’m sorry. I’m sorry. I’m not calling you crazy. I’m calling the situation crazy.”

Lana stared down at her tea again.

Charlotte’s voice softened. “I’m just scared.”

Lana looked up. “You’re scared?”

Charlotte laughed again, but this time it sounded like she was about to cry.

“Yes, I’m scared,” she said. “I’m terrified. Lana, I’m literally soaked right now because I ran here after you texted me, and I thought I was about to walk in and find you dead or something.”

Lana’s chest squeezed. “Char…”

Charlotte pointed at her again, but her hand was shaking now. “No. Listen. You don’t get it.”

Lana whispered, “Then tell me.”

Charlotte stared at her for a second, like she didn’t want to say what had been bottled up inside because if she did, she’d break open. Then she said it anyway. “You are not the only person who lost David.”

Lana froze.

Charlotte’s voice began to crack. “I know you lost him more. Obviously. He was your husband, but he was also my friend.”

Lana blinked fast. Tears started spilling again.

Charlotte kept going. “He was the only boyfriend you ever had that I liked,” Charlotte said. “And that’s saying a lot because your taste before him was horrible.”

Lana whispered, “Stop.”

“No,” Charlotte snapped. “Because it’s true. He was good. He was actually good.”

Lana pressed her lips together hard like she was trying not to sob. Charlotte wiped the tears off her face aggressively and wept. “I miss him,” her voice broke. “I miss him so bad it makes me sick sometimes.” Lana’s breath caught as Charlotte’s eyes squinted shut. “And now you’re telling me he’s calling you, and I don’t know if I want to scream or throw up or run away.”

Lana whispered, “I’m sorry.”

Charlotte took a breath, calmer than before but still shaking. “You don’t get to apologize for being sad. That’s not fair.”

“I didn’t mean that.”

Charlotte exhaled and sat back down on the couch beside Lana, close enough that their knees touched. For a second, neither of them spoke.

Then Lana whispered, “I just want him back.”

“I know.”

Lana’s voice cracked. “I don’t even care if it’s stupid. I don’t even care if it’s not real. I just… I heard him, and it felt like I wasn’t dying for a second.”

Charlotte swallowed hard, then muttered, “Yeah. That’s the part that scares me.”

Lana turned toward her. “What part?”

Charlotte’s voice got shaky again. “That you’re going to start needing it.”

“Needing it?”

“Yes. Like a drug. Like you’re gonna sit here every night waiting for it to happen again. And if it doesn’t happen, you’re gonna break. And if it does happen, you’re gonna break.”

“Char…”

Charlotte’s voice rose again. “You can’t win.”

“I don’t know how to help you anymore.”

That sentence hit Lana harder than anything else tonight, but she somehow muttered back to her, “You’re here.”

Charlotte laughed weakly. “That’s not helping, Lana. That’s me panicking in your bedroom.”

Lana whispered, “But you’re still here.”

Charlotte’s face twisted like she might cry again. “I can’t lose you, too.”

“You’re not going to.”

Charlotte scoffed. “Don’t say that like you can control it.”

Lana’s voice cracked. “I can control myself.”

Charlotte looked at her like she didn’t even believe that. Then she whispered, “You’re scaring me.”

Lana's tears spilled faster now. "I'm scared too."

They sat in silence for a while. The quietness in the room spread like the scent of a freshly lit candle, slowly engulfing the room with its smell.

Charlotte pointed at her. "You are calling your therapist tomorrow. Like actually. Not 'maybe.' Not 'I'll see how I feel.' Tomorrow."

Lana nodded quickly. "Okay."

Charlotte pointed again. "And you're not staying here alone all day."

Lana blinked. "Char…"

"No," Charlotte said immediately. "Don't argue. I'm staying."

Lana's chest warmed. "You are?"

"Yes." Charlotte rolled her eyes. "Because I don't trust you right now."

Lana looked down at her tea. "I'm trying."

Charlotte's voice softened. "I know you are." She stood up and walked to her bag in the corner of the room. "I am going to call Carol and tell her she has the kid for the day. I can't keep doing this, Lana. This is the last time for a while. But I am here because I love you."

Lana whispered, "Okay."

Charlotte's lips formed a line as she leaned her shoulder into Lana's. "I love you so much, Lana."

Lana's tears finally spilled fully. She leaned into Charlotte like she couldn't hold herself up anymore. Charlotte wrapped an arm around her.

Charlotte whispered into her hair, "I hate that he left you."

Lana sobbed, then swallowed hard. "I hate that he left us."

Chapter 10

June 2024

Lana woke up slowly, not because of some loud sound coming from the dumpster or a spooky nightmare, no. This was something different. She stared up at the ceiling through the dark bedroom air, confused at first, trying to figure out what had awakened her. David was beside her, asleep on his back with one arm above his head and the other resting on her arm. The only sounds she could hear were the hum of the ceiling fan and the exhales of David's breath.

She shifted slightly beneath the blanket to settle back into sleep, but then she felt it. Warm wetness, spreading beneath her like a wildfire. Her stomach dropped hard, like the floor fell out beneath her. Lana moved her hand down slowly. Her fingers slipped beneath the waistband of her shorts and pressed against the fabric. When she pulled her hand back, even in the dark, she could tell.

It was blood.

For a moment, her brain couldn't comprehend it. She stared at her hand like it wasn't her own. Like she was in some sort of dream, and her body didn't decide to give up on her in the middle of the night. Her breath caught in her throat, and she whispered, "No," so softly it was mostly just air.

When she sat up, the movement made it worse. The warmth slid down her thighs as she pushed the blanket off quickly and swung her legs over the side of the bed. Her feet hit the hardwood, and she felt the cold against her skin. Her body trembled as she stood. She was so

dizzy that she was unsure if she was going to faint or throw up. She took shaky steps toward the bathroom before stopping for a moment to look back at the bed. There was already a stain on the sheet, like ink poured onto paper. Lana stared at it and realized that her greatest fear may be coming true.

She stumbled into the bathroom and flicked on the light, and the brightness overwhelmed her. It turned her skin pale in the mirror and made the blood look darker. Lana looked down and saw more blood. The blood had soaked through her shorts, streaking down her legs in thin lines that made her stomach twist. Her hands shook violently as she tugged the fabric down, her heart hammering so loudly she could hear it, and she sat on the toilet with her knees pulled in slightly, staring at the floor.

She waited for it to stop. She waited for her body to correct itself and realize it was doing something it wasn't supposed to do. But nothing stopped, and the blood kept coming. Lana's vision blurred as tears filled her eyes, coating them with a glossy film. Her hands flew to her stomach, and she pressed her palm there as if she could hold onto what was inside her.

She had been scared when she saw the positive test. Terrified of the future and the responsibility, and the unknown parts that being a mom would entail. She had told Charlotte she wasn't ready, but Charlotte had promised her that no one was ever really ready. Lana had believed that fear was the worst part, but fear was nothing compared to this.

Lana grabbed toilet paper and desperately wiped. She would check and then wipe again, hoping it would lessen and the color would fade, but she looked down again, and there was more

blood, even darker than before. She felt like her lungs were caving in. Every breath was a labor. “No,” she whispered louder this time, shaking her head. “No, no, no, please.”

She reached for her phone on the counter. Her fingers were slipping because they were shaking too hard. She needed to call someone: Charlotte or a doctor. But before she could even unlock the phone, her eyes glanced at a figure in the doorway.

David stood in the bathroom doorway. He looked half asleep, his shoulders were slumped, and his eyes were heavy. For a second, Lana felt a flash of relief, but then his gaze dropped from her face to her legs, to the blood. His expression changed so quickly that Lana almost didn’t catch it. It was not panic, concern, or the fear she expected to see. Instead, there was this kind of stillness and coldness that settled on his face.

Lana’s throat tightened. “David,” she choked out.

David didn’t move toward her. He didn’t come close to rush in and kneel down and take her hands like she thought he would. No. He just stared at her like she was some sort of circus freak. He looked at her as if he didn’t even recognize her. Lana’s eyes filled again, and she whispered, “Something’s wrong,” even though the entire bathroom was proof of that.

David blinked slowly, and it made Lana’s stomach drop further because he didn’t look concerned. He looked mad. Lana hated herself for letting the idea sink its claws into her, but it was there anyway. His eyes felt too sharp, his mouth too tight, and the longer he stood there, the more Lana felt like she was being judged.

“I didn’t do anything,” she whispered, her voice shaking. “I swear I didn’t.” She just wanted him to say something.

David’s jaw tightened, just enough for Lana to notice. Tears slid down her cheeks, and she shook her head again. She pleaded to David, “I didn’t do this on purpose! David, I didn’t do anything wrong.”

Maybe it was hormones or the fear, but the way David looked at her felt wrong in a way she couldn’t explain. His gaze dropped to her stomach again, then lifted back to her face. His eyes looked darker now.

Then he said, quietly but clearly, “You promised.”

Lana froze like she’d been slapped. Her lips parted, but no sound came out at first. “What?” she whispered, shaking her head. “David, what do you mean?”

David didn’t soften or step closer to comfort her. He just stayed where he was, anchored in the doorway. “You said you wanted this,” he said with no emotion.

“I do,” Lana sobbed. “I do, I do. I do want this. I wanted this, David, I swear…”

David blinked again, and his eyes narrowed slightly. “Then why couldn’t you keep it?” he asked.

The sentence hit her so hard her whole body went numb. Lana’s breath left her in one gasp, and she stared at him in shock, shaking her head like she couldn't process what she was hearing. “That’s not fair,” she choked out. “That’s not… David, don’t say that.”

But David didn't respond or apologize. He didn't look guilty for saying it. He just stared at her like it was true, like it was all her fault. She felt like her body was a crime scene, and she was the criminal standing in the middle of it.

At that moment, Lana broke. She sobbed so loudly and so ugly. "I'm sorry," she cried, even though she didn't even know what she was apologizing for anymore. "I'm sorry," she repeated, over and over.

"I'm sorry."

"I'm sorry."

"I'm sorry."

"I'm sorry."

"I'm sorry."

David stepped forward, and for one wild second Lana's chest flared with hope that he was finally going to come to her, that he was finally going to wrap his arms around her and tell her she wasn't alone, that he was finally going to be the David she knew. Lana lifted her head, desperate, her eyes swollen and hands trembling.

But he didn't touch her. He walked past her and out of the bathroom. Like she disgusted him.

The doorway emptied, and Lana stared after him, listening as his footsteps disappeared into the bedroom. A quiet click followed when the bedroom door shut.

Lana sat there under the harsh bathroom light, blood still warm, and her chest aching. She stared down at her stomach, her hand resting there. Her tears fell onto her skin, and she couldn't stop them.

The rain continued outside, tapping and tapping. How fitting it was to rain on a night like this. Lana squeezed her eyes shut, and there was only one thought that remained in her head.

If David was mad at her, then she must have deserved it.

Chapter 11

November 2025

The rain continued throughout the night, and the large oak tree outside of Lana's bedroom window created a constant beat that matched the pounding in her chest. Charlotte had left just about an hour ago, leaving Lana to confront her thoughts once again. As she turned over to face the empty side of the bed, she felt the crushing weight of loneliness settle over her again. She was swallowed by her own thoughts.

I just want someone to believe me. I am sick of being alone in this battle.

That conversation with Charlotte had hit her hard. She knew when talking to her that she would be blunt. She was always blunt. But she also knew she needed to hear the truth, and Charlotte was the only one who would tell it.

Ever since the accident, people tiptoed around her. They acted as if she were either insane, a child, or just a basket case. They would make excuses for her. Ones that even she knew were just to make her feel better. But Charlotte didn't do that. No. Charlotte was the one who would get her out of even the deepest ruts.

When David's funeral was approaching, Lana almost didn't go. She told Charlotte and her mom that it was too hard. Her mom just agreed, saying that maybe it was okay for her to stay home and that no one should force her to do anything. But Charlotte, even though she knew it was hard, made her go. She told her she would regret it for the rest of her life if she decided to

stay home instead of saying goodbye to her husband one last time. Lana was happy she went. It was hard, but it started to give her even the slightest ounce of closure.

She began to finally close her eyes and drift off into a dream.

It was a pleasant one. The dream. In it, she was lying on the beach with a margarita in one hand and the first book in her favorite fantasy series that she would get to read for the first time again in the other. Everything was colorful, calm, and silent. Like one of those noise machines that dispersed the perfect ocean noises.

Then, interrupting her utopia, came that jarring noise.

BUZZ

Her phone vibrated on the nightstand. The screen illuminated the dark bedroom. She wanted to ignore it, to shut out this impossible conversation, but something inside urged her to bring that cold metal phone to her ear.

No silence this time. That familiar voice, urgent and clear, spoke to her through the line. “Lana, listen to me. He is still out there, the guy who killed me. They got the wrong guy.”

A tightening in her chest made her gasp and shoot to her feet. Was this real, or was she still dreaming?

“What are you talking about? That's impossible.” She began to cry into her phone. “He confessed. It had to have been him.”

A long and heavy pause stretched between them. The rain filled the silence.

“They were wrong. All of them,” David whispered, seeming even more rushed now than before. “You can’t trust anyone. He is still out there, and he has to be stopped.”

Chills echoed through Lana's body, and goosebumps bloomed like frost spreading across a window frame.

“Why are you calling me?” she asked, her voice barely more than a breath. “What am I supposed to do?”

“I’m sorry, my Lady Bug, I must go.” His voice cracked. She knew he was crying.

“You always looked so cute in my clothes.”

She froze. Then the line went dead.

She looked down at the sleeves of the flannel, David's old flannel, hanging loosely over her frame. Then, from the corner of her eye, just beyond the glass, she saw a dark figure move somewhere behind the oak tree, as if it did not want to be seen.

David?

Her mouth went dry.

Without hesitation, Lana slipped her feet into the nearest pair of shoes and sprinted toward the door. The knob was cold in her hand, and the air was sharp and damp as she ran out into the night.

To him.

But there was no one there. The figure was gone. She was once again alone, the rain drenching her in seconds. The only sound around her was the rain playing a haunting melody against the earth and the screeching, endless tone still ringing from her phone.

But how was it possible? How did this voice know what she was wearing? How did it know this was David's flannel?

And what the voice said. How could it be true? David was killed in a car accident by a young, drunk driver. There was security footage of the man leaving a bar one night, getting into his car, and t-boning David on his way back from the gym. The trial was short. The kid confessed, his eyes filled with tears the entire time.

She always wanted to be mad at that kid. But she felt worse for him than anything. She could see in his eyes that it was a mistake. It was a mistake that so many people before him had gotten away with. The amount of times she got behind the wheel when she had had a little too much to drink in college or got in the car with someone who did. She knew it was wrong. She knew David's death was his fault. But she also knew that he was the one who did it. No one else.

“Are you okay?”

Lana jumped. A voice from afar startled her.

Her neighbor, Mrs. Kent, stood on her porch, umbrella in hand, with a look of concern beneath her gray, weathered hair.

“Yeah, sorry, just thought I saw someone,” Lana said, brushing a soaked piece of hair from her cheek. “Have a good night.”

Mrs. Kent gave a slow nod, grabbed her old wooden cane that hung next to the door, and entered back into the house. Before she closed the door, she gave Lana that concerned smile that everyone seemed to give her, the door clicking behind her.

Lana stood statuesque beneath the unceasing rain. Each drop was a cold touch from nature, drenching her to the core. Reality began to blur under the hazy curtain of gray, and confusion danced in her mind. She was soaked, not just from the rain but from the fear and uncertainty that engulfed her.

Shivering, Lana walked back inside, closing and locking the door behind her. She grabbed a warm towel from the linen closet and wrapped it tightly around her shoulders.

She sank into that old beanbag in the library and tried to feel some warmth in the room beneath the stars. The time-worn clock struck two, its sound lingering like a ghost in the night.

A knock came about twenty minutes later. A very light knock. Lana hesitated, the towel still wrapped tightly around her shoulders, damp hair dripping onto the collarbone of David's flannel. For a second, fear flared again, and her pulse spiked.

Then she heard Mrs. Kent's voice through the door. "Lana," she said gently. "It's just me."

Lana unlocked the door. Mrs. Kent stood on the porch without her umbrella this time, rain misting lightly over her hair. She held a cigarette between two fingers, unlit.

“I hope I’m not bothering you,” Mrs. Kent said. “I saw your light was still on.”

Lana shook her head. “No. I… I wasn’t planning on sleeping anyway.”

Mrs. Kent nodded, as if that made complete sense. She gestured toward the porch railing. “Do you mind if we sit here for a minute?”

“Please.”

They sat side by side on the wooden porch steps. The rain had softened to barely a drizzle. The oak tree dripped onto the concrete sidewalk, and the air still smelled like rain.

Mrs. Kent lit the cigarette with a practiced flick of her lighter. The flame briefly illuminated her face. Lana could see every wrinkle, every line, and every crease in her face. All of which she knew were earned through a life well lived.

She took a puff, then held the cigarette out toward Lana. “You don’t smoke, do you?”

Lana shook her head. “No.”

“Good,” Mrs. Kent said. “Don’t start. This is just an old woman’s bad habit.”

She exhaled, smoke curling into the damp night air. Its white cloud followed the wind's whoosh. They sat in silence for a moment, taking in the sounds of the night.

“You looked frightened earlier,” Mrs. Kent said finally. Not accusatory, but just a genuine observation.

Lana swallowed. Her hands were tucked into the towel. “I thought I saw someone.”

Mrs. Kent nodded again. “You said that.”

Lana stared out at the yard. The oak tree stood tall and almost seemed to be watching her. “I know how it sounds.”

Mrs. Kent took another puff. “I didn’t say it sounded like anything.”

That made Lana look at her. Mrs. Kent seemed to understand her. Whether it was through her eyes that seemed to see straight into her or her smile that was filled with understanding, Lana knew she understood.

“You know,” Mrs. Kent said, tapping ash into the rain-soaked dirt, “after my husband died, I heard him for months.”

Lana’s breath caught. “You did?”

“Oh yes,” Mrs. Kent said calmly. “Footsteps. The creak of his chair. Once, I swear, I heard him clear his throat like he used to before he spoke.” She threw the cigarette into a small bag in her purse. “Grief does strange things to the mind.”

Lana let out a sarcastic laugh. “That’s what everyone keeps saying.”

The rain seemed to hush around them. Mrs. Kent didn’t push. She didn’t ask questions. She just waited, a cigarette glowing faintly in the dark.

“Sometimes he calls me,” Lana whispered. “But, I don’t know if it's real or just in my mind.”

Mrs. Kent nodded once. “Maybe it's both.”

Lana's eyes filled, but she didn't wipe them away this time. "Everyone keeps acting like I'm… fragile. Like I can't be trusted with my own thoughts."

Mrs. Kent's voice softened. "People get scared when they don't understand something. Easier to label it than to listen."

Lana laughed weakly. "Somehow, I feel like you aren't scared. Like you understand me."

"I just know what you are going through," Mrs. Kent agreed. "Some people are built to stand in the storm with you."

They sat quietly again. Mrs. Kent smoked. Lana breathed. "I'm not saying what you heard was real," she said carefully. "And I'm not saying it wasn't."

Lana nodded. How had she never realized her neighbor was so wise?

"But I am saying this," Mrs. Kent continued. "You're not crazy. And you're not alone. If something feels wrong, you're allowed to trust that feeling."

Lana hugged the towel tighter around herself, emotion pressing hard against her ribs. "Thank you."

Mrs. Kent slowly stood, her joints protesting her age. "Any time you need a porch and someone to listen," she said, tapping her cane lightly, "mine's right there." She paused at her door, then glanced back.

"And Lana?"

"Yes?"

“If you see something again,” Mrs. Kent said, “you come get me before you go chasing shadows by yourself.”

A small smile tugged at Lana’s lips. “Deal.”

Mrs. Kent went inside, the door closing softly behind her. Lana stayed on the porch a while longer, wrapped in her towel, listening to the rain and the steady drip from the oak tree.

Chapter 12

July 2024

The arguments never started as arguments. No. They always started the same way: very calm and slowly. It was like both of them were stepping over trip wires, trying not to trigger the other.

One specific night, Lana stood in the kitchen with a glass of wine in her hand that was already on its second refill. The bottle sat uncorked on the counter. The kitchen window was cracked, even though the summer air was humid, letting in a mix of city smells and flowers. The heat made sweat cling to the back of her neck, and her hair stuck to her skin slightly. She could feel the buzz just beginning to settle, making everything just a little bit quieter. David sat at the small kitchen table with his arms crossed as he watched her take another sip.

“You didn’t tell me you weren’t coming home last night,” he said.

Lana took a sip of her wine instead of answering. “I texted you,” she said with no tone whatsoever.

“You texted me at one in the morning,” David replied, clearly annoyed. “After I’d already fallen asleep.”

She shrugged and set the glass down on the counter next to her with a soft clink.“Okay. And?”

“And I woke up at six in the morning thinking something had happened to you.”

Lana laughed once and set his comment aside, “You’re being dramatic.”

David blinked, clearly caught off guard. “I’m being dramatic?”

“Yes,” she said, already reaching for the bottle again to refill her glass, “You survived six hours without knowing where I was. Congratulations.”

“Lana, that’s not what this is about.”

She picked up the glass and took a longer sip this time. “Then what is it about?”

David hesitated. She hated when he paused like that, like he was trying to select the least hurtful words from his internal dictionary. “You’ve been gone a lot,” he said finally. “Physically. Mentally. Emotionally. I don’t know which one is worse anymore.”

Lana scoffed. “Oh my God, here we go.”

“Why do you always say that?”

“Because every time you start a sentence like that,” she snapped, pushing herself off the counter, “It ends with you dissecting me like I’m some kind of project you’re trying to fix or like you are psychoanalyzing me or something.”

“That’s not fair,” he said quietly.

“Neither is constantly being monitored,” she shot back. “I’m allowed to go out. I’m allowed to have friends. I’m allowed to drink a glass of wine without it turning into a fucking diagnosis.”

David's eyes shifted to the half-empty bottle and then to the glass, "That's not one glass."

Her emotions turned red. "Wow. So now you're counting."

"I'm noticing," he said. "There's a difference."

"No, there isn't," Lana rebutted, "You're judging me."

"I'm worried about you."

The word worried landed wrong; it just felt like pity, and she hated to be pitied, "I didn't ask you to be," she snapped.

David stared at her, stunned by what he felt like was a stranger in front of him, "You didn't ask me to care?"

She lifted the glass again just to avoid answering, "I didn't ask you to act like my mom."

"I'm your husband," he said. "Caring comes with the job."

"Well, maybe you're bad at it," Lana said, and the ease of the words scared her.

The silence between them was almost unbearable. It was only interrupted by laughter drifting in through the open window from somewhere down the street. Someone else's summer night was going a lot better than theirs.

David's voice softened, "You've been drinking more," he said. "You barely sleep. You barely talk to me, and when you do, it's like you're not even real. Oh, and you're always at that bar…Moss and Oak, or whatever it's called. I just… I miss the old you."

Lana went still. There has been a lot unsaid between them ever since that night. The night when she lay helplessly on the bathroom floor, and all David did was just watch her. She set the glass down on the counter, carefully this time, “I haven’t been the same since the baby,” she said quietly. She stared at the wall, anywhere but at him. “And the way you looked at me after… It’s like I didn’t even know you.”

“That’s not fair.”

“It’s how it felt,” She turned around to meet his eyes, “Like I ruined everything. Like my body failed and you couldn’t even look at me.”

“I was scared,” he said. “I didn’t know how to help you.”

“I didn’t need help,” Lana snapped. “I needed you to stay.”

“I did stay,” he said. “I’m still here.”

She laughed, bitterly. “But you weren’t there when I needed you.” Lana paused and then let everything that had been building up for the last month come out. “I lay on the floor of that fucking bathroom in the worst state of my life, and you just stared at me and shamed me. Did you ever even love me, or did you just use me to make your children, and, when I couldn’t do that, I was just a failed machine?”

David was left almost speechless. “Lana, that's not how I view you.”

Lana shuddered then continued, “Is it? Because I know we haven’t had sex in weeks. Is that because you only wanted to fuck me for a baby and not because you actually loved me? Why marry me then? Did you ever even love me?”

“I asked to marry the Lana I met in college. Not this alcoholic loser you are now,” David snapped, fist slamming against the table.

At this point, something inside Lana snapped. Her hand closed around the wine glass without her thinking about it. The motion was fast. The glass left her hand and shattered against the wall behind David, exploding into fragments that clattered to the floor.

The sound was deafening.

Lana stood there shaking, her chest heaving, staring at what she’d done. David didn’t move or yell. He just looked at the broken glass, then back at her, his face pale.

“I can’t do this,” she said, her voice breaking. “I can’t keep feeling like I’m the problem in my own god damn house.”

“You just threw a fucking glass at me.”

“I know,” she said through glossy eyes. “And I hate that I did that, but that’s where I’m at.”

Lana stormed into the bedroom and began shoving clothes into a suitcase. Not folded or organized, but a big pile. She put all her effort into shoving the bag shut and had to throw some extra clothes on the floor to get it to finally close.

David entered the bedroom. “So you are just going to leave?”

Lana remained silent for a moment, picked up the suitcase, and walked to the door. Before she left, she looked into his eyes. “Yeah, I am leaving. I am going to my mom's. Now maybe you will know what it's like to be left when you are at your worst, too.” She closed the door before he could even respond.

Chapter 13

November 2025

Lana stood on the edge of her kitchen counter, having a staring contest with her phone. Its cracked body sat ever so peacefully on the counter as its glass reflected the morning's golden hues. The reflection warped slightly where the glass was already fractured, bending the light in a hundred different ways. The phone looked harmless and innocent like this, but Lana knew better.

The weight of the hammer felt heavy in her hand, not just because of its steel head but because of the choice that it symbolized. Lana had used it before, years ago, when David insisted on hanging the shelves themselves instead of paying someone. Back then, it had been a tool. A means to build something. Now it was going to be used for the opposite.

She was done with this, with whatever mysterious person was calling her. She was done negotiating with her own sanity. She knew David. She knew he wouldn't act like this or call her in such a violent and revengeful tone. That voice didn't belong to the man who used to apologize when he accidentally spoke too loudly. It didn't belong to the man who whispered to her instead of raising his voice, even when he was angry.

Her palms began to drip sweat onto the wooden and worn handle of the hammer. The grip grew slick, and she tightened her fingers instinctively, afraid it might slip. Her stomach twisted as nausea began to bloom.

She knew David. Well, she thought she did. He was perfect, always perfect. Or at least that was how grief framed him to be. Lana's therapist had told her once that grief had a tendency

to soften a lost one's edges and that it would polish their flaws until they shone so much brighter than anyone ever could. He used to tell her that part of her grieving was to picture David as perfect and that, when she realized he wasn't some saint, she would start to be able to move on. But she seemed to struggle to find anything wrong with him. He was the man who got her out of the infinite time loop. He was the man who put up fairy lights and would always tell her everything was going to be alright. He was perfect…

But there was that night.

The night he caught her lying on the floor, bleeding. Crying over the loss of their child. The memory started to play back, uninvited yet so vivid. The bathroom light buzzed overhead as she cried. She could barely smell the blood on the floor through the tears dripping down her face, and her throat felt like it was going to close. She remembered the way the world had narrowed to pain. Pure emotional pain. At that moment, she needed him more than she had ever needed him. But he just stood there and did nothing. The David she had always known and had always loved had eyes that glowed with an unfamiliar light. His true colors showed that night. That memory had lived inside of her like an infection.

But David was never violent or paranoid. He was always calm and would never ask for revenge. He always believed anger burned out eventually if you didn't feed it. But, above all, David was dead, and as far as she knew, calls from the underworld weren't common.

She couldn't let grief continue to carve illusions into her mind. She couldn't keep slipping between reality and fantasy. She knew that this needed to stop. Not tomorrow. Not later. Now. Before she lost the ability to tell which thoughts were hers and which ones grief had planted.

Her arms began to rise above her head.

For a fraction of a second, she hesitated. A thought flashed through her mind.

What if this is a mistake? What if this is the only proof I have?

The fear came fast and sharp, but she crushed it. Proof wasn't worth her sanity. Nothing was.

Crack.

The first blow shattered the screen, splintering it into a web of broken glass. The sound ricocheted through the kitchen, making her flinch even though the hammer was already lifting again. The screen fractured like a rock penetrating ice on a frozen lake.

Crack.

The second strike sent a key flying across the room, ricocheting off the wall and vanishing beneath the refrigerator. The phone's body warped inward, metal bending with a sickening groan. Lana's breath came fast and shallow now, her chest burning as if she were running.

Crack. Crack. Crack…

She didn't stop. She couldn't stop, as each strike felt less controlled than the last. She was driven by something feral and desperate. Glass leapt from the table. She was like an animal. Her arms ached, and her hands stung, but she still kept going. She couldn't stop. Not until all that was

left was a pile of mangled metal scattered across the kitchen counter. The phone no longer resembled anything but scraps.

After that, everything was silent. All that remained was the sound of her heavy breathing and the dripping of blood on the counter. The drips matched the ticking of the kitchen clock.

Tick, drip, tick, drip.

Her blood fell slowly, one drop at a time, dark and warm. She had gotten so lost in the moment that she didn't even realize she had cut her cheek open on a piece of glass. The adrenaline had halted the sting of pain. She touched her face carefully, fingers still shaking, and stared at the blood on her fingertips. She had never felt that much rage before. That much power.

She knew what was real, and she knew what was impossible. The phone lay destroyed in front of her, and she knew it was dead, and dead things stayed dead. Voices didn’t come back. No matter how desperately she wanted them to.

She set the hammer down beside her, wiping the blood from her cheek with the sleeve of her sweatshirt. She leaned against the counter, knees weak, eyes closing as the noise inside her head slowly receded.

She began to feel the weight of this moment overcome her. The strange grief of destroying something that had terrified her. Finally, the noises inside her head began to quiet, and she felt a sense of peace with the world again. The fragile calm that follows devastation, when everything is broken but quiet at last. And for the first time in days, Lana was alone with her thoughts, and they weren’t screaming.

Chapter 14

August 2024

As the days passed, Lana took off work and spent some quality time with her mom and brother. She watched The Price Is Right with them every night and ate about five pecan pies in less than twenty-four hours. Her mom shouted guesses at the screen, hoping they would magically make her win a flat-screen TV. Her brother pretended not to care but leaned forward during the Showcase Showdown anyway. Lana laughed more than she expected to. She ate pecan pie straight from the tin at midnight, then again for breakfast, then again because her mom insisted it would go bad. By the end of the day, she felt sick from sugar.

Her mom took her to get her nails done one afternoon. Lana picked a soft, neutral color similar to the one she wore every day in high school. Even years later, the nail salon smelled like acetone and lavender, and for forty-five minutes, she didn't have to talk. She just existed, hands resting in warm water, enjoying time with her mom.

Lana loved spending time with her family, but with how busy she got at work, she struggled to make the three-hour drive to the suburbs to see them. When her niece was first born, she would come home almost every weekend. But as time passed and she got older, it became harder.

Being there felt like stepping back in time in a way that was both comforting and painful. Her childhood bedroom hadn't changed much. It still had the same pale walls, the same dresser that still stuck when you pulled the bottom drawer too hard, and the same faint smell of laundry

detergent and dust. She even fell back into her old routines. She slept later than usual. She laughed more easily. She let her mom fuss over her in that way mothers do when they know something is wrong but don't want to press too hard.

But no matter how full the days were with Jenga and Solitaire, the nights always caught up to her.

One night, her brother and his wife cooked an overly elaborate dinner. There were cloth napkins, real wine glasses, and candles. Lana watched them move around the kitchen together, bumping into each other, arguing lightly over garlic, and she felt something twist in her chest. It wasn't jealousy. It was loneliness. It was longing to dance around the kitchen with David or lie on the ground and stargaze together once again.

After the TV turned off and everyone went silent, Lana lay awake, staring at the ceiling fan as it slowly spun above her. Her phone sat on the nightstand, silent and face down.

She checked it before she took a shower. And then after she got out. Again after she dried her hair. Again after she brushed her teeth. Again and again, hoping for a message. David hadn't texted her since the fight over a week ago. She wanted to reach out to apologize. To tell him that she loved him and just wanted to forget about it all. She would stop drinking for him. She would go back to being herself for him. Or at least try to. But she knew they needed space and that, when the time was right, she would text him. Still, part of her wished he would just show up at her door with a bouquet of flowers and beg for her back. But this wasn't some romance novel; this was real life.

One afternoon, while Lana sat at the kitchen table absentmindedly picking at the edge of a napkin, her mom slid a mug of tea in front of her and sat down across from her. “You know you can talk to me if you need to,” she said gently. “I may be your mom, but I can also be your friend.”

Lana let a small smile form and replied, “I don’t know if I left because I needed space,” she said, eyes fixed on the table, “or because I was scared of what would happen if I stayed. I was scared I would be the one to leave if I didn’t go first.”

Her mom nodded understandingly. “You know it can be both too.”

Lana looked up. “Is that… normal?”

Her mom smiled faintly. “Unfortunately? Yes.” She leaned back in her chair, eyes drifting toward the window. “When your father and I were first engaged, we fought more than I ever admitted to anyone.”

Lana frowned. This was surprising information to her. “Really? You guys always seemed so solid.”

Her mom let out a quiet laugh. “Oh, honey. We were a mess.”

“A mess?”

She laughed, took a sip of her tea, then set the mug down. “There was a point where I stayed with your grandparents for two weeks. I didn’t tell many people that.”

“What happened?” Lana asked.

Her mom hesitated, then said, “You happened.”

Lana blinked. “Me?”

“You were a baby,” her mom said gently. “And I loved you more than I knew was possible, but I was exhausted. My body didn’t feel like mine anymore. My mind didn’t feel like mine, and your father felt like I was shutting him out.”

Lana swallowed. “I never knew.”

“We didn’t know how to talk about it,” her mom admitted. “Postpartum was harder than anyone warned me it would be. I felt like I was grieving the version of myself that existed before you, and I felt guilty for grieving her at all.” She shook her head. “Your father thought I didn’t love him anymore. I thought he didn’t see me.”

Lana’s chest tightened. “Did you ever think about leaving for good?”

Her mom didn’t answer right away. “No,” she said finally. “I didn’t. I knew he was my lobster.”

Lana and her mom laughed. She knew she was right. Ever since her father passed when she was 12, her mom wanted to try dating again but never was able to. She had her fair share of first dates and one-night stands, but when Lana was around 15 or 16, she gave up entirely on love again. Lobsters only ever have one mate, and her mom was the same way.

Lana stared down at her hands. “What if I come back and it’s still broken?”

Her mom reached across the table and turned Lana's hand over, brushing her thumb gently over her palm. "Then you decide whether it's something you can fix together… or something you need to walk away from."

Lana's voice cracked. "I don't know which one this is."

"That's okay," her mom said softly. "You're not supposed to know yet."

Lana laughed weakly. "Everyone else seems to know."

Her mom scoffed. "Everyone else isn't you."

Silence fell again. The house creaked softly around them. "I feel like I'm failing," Lana said suddenly. "At marriage. In life. At everything."

"You're not failing. You're hurting."

Lana shook her head. "I yell. I drink too much. I say things I don't mean."

"So do a lot of people," her mom said. "The difference is that you're holding yourself to an impossible standard."

Lana's throat tightened. "David deserves better."

Her mom studied her carefully. "David deserves honesty and effort. Not perfection." She paused. "And you deserve someone who stays when things get ugly, not someone who makes you feel like you're the problem for struggling."

Lana flinched and defended him. "He didn't mean to."

“I know,” her mom said gently. “But intention doesn’t erase impact.”

Lana inhaled shakily. “I miss him.”

Her mom nodded. “Of course you do.”

“I miss the way things used to be,” Lana added. Her lip began to quiver. “Before everything got so fucking hard.”

Her mom rose from her chair and gave Lana a much-needed hug. They sat there for a moment. The smell of cookies in the oven, the sound of the window creaking against the lemon tree outside, and the feeling of her mom’s sweater around her made her remember: she was home. That no matter how bad her life may be back in the city, she would always have this family.

“Mom?” she said.

“Yes?”

“Are you mad at me for leaving?”

Her mom looked genuinely surprised. “No.”

“Not even a little?”

“No,” she said firmly. “I’m proud of you for knowing when you needed air.”

Lana’s eyes filled again. “I feel like a child.”

Her mom smiled, reaching up to brush a strand of hair from Lana's face. "That's okay. Sometimes I like feeling needed again."

"I just want things to stop hurting."

Her mom stood and pulled her into a hug once again. "I know."

Lana pressed her face into her mom's shoulder, breathing her in. For a moment, she let herself be held without worrying about what came next.

That night, Lana finally texted David.

She stared at the blinking cursor for a long time before typing. She erased three drafts before settling on something simple.

Lana: Can we talk?

The reply came quicker than she expected.

David: Yeah. Anytime.

The Final Call

Chapter 15

November 2025

The library felt like the only room in the apartment that never asked Lana for anything. The bedroom demanded she turn off her mind and sleep. The kitchen demanded that she start each day as if everything were normal. The living room demanded she live. It wanted her to live this life and move on from something she didn't want to move on from.

But, in her mind, the library demanded nothing from her. It had always been quiet. It acted like a place where she could escape reality for a while. Whether it was through a story of a princess in a faraway land or by counting the stars on the ceiling, it was her own fantasy land.

The fairy lights still traced the molding along the ceiling, tiny stars glowing against the deep blue paint. She thought about David, but in a happy way. She remembered him standing on a chair, paintbrush in hand, speckling the ceiling with uneven dots while she sat on the floor, laughing every time one landed crooked.

She awoke from her daydream and began slowly walking around the room. Her fingers brushed the spines as she passed, tracing familiar titles. She knew where every book in that library was. Romance on the left wall. Fantasy and sci-fi, most of which were David's, on the right. Poetry near the window, where the light was best in the afternoons.

She sank down onto the beanbag; it sighed beneath her weight as she nestled into place. The teddy bear David won at a boardwalk game years ago rested beside her. She swore it still smelled like funnel cake and burnt popcorn.

She pulled the blanket tighter around herself and stared at the shelves across from her, letting her mind drift once again.

She thought of the way David used to sit cross-legged on the floor with his back against the shelves. They used to sit silently together and read. He would pause mid-sentence to explain some ridiculous detail, then look up, eyes bright, waiting to see if she was listening.

She had learned over these months that grief was not just missing someone, but feeling like they were everywhere. It was like the past and the present were constantly colliding and intertwining. It was seeing him everywhere and nowhere at the same time. It was knowing, in her mind, that he was gone, yet her heart still craved his voice.

She pressed her lips together, swallowing hard. Her gaze flicked to the old desk across the room. In that mystical library, there was an antique rotary phone. Its golden keys clashed against its raven body, lifeless as it had not been plugged in for over a decade.

The clock continued its steady ticking.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

Her eyes drifted back to the clock.

As if rising from the grave, at 1:43 a.m., the sounds of that ancient phone echoed throughout the house.

Ring. Ring.

Lana sat frozen, wrapped in her fuzzy blanket. The rotary phone rang again.

Ring. Ring.

Lana stood up, soaked in moonlight, and wrapped her robe around her like armor. Her bare feet rooted to the floor as if the phone would come to her.

Ring. Ring.

She crept toward the phone. Tears began to stream down her face.

The library was always a place of comfort for her, but now the stars no longer shimmered; they stared. She lifted the phone to her ear, hands shaking.

No static.

No silence.

Just his voice.

“You can’t run from this, Lana.” His tone was no longer fragile and scared. It was strong. It was demanding. “His name is Jeremy Koss. He needs to be killed to bring me the justice I deserve. This needs to be done, or more people will get hurt.”

Her breath caught again. “No,” she demanded. “No, David. I am not a killer, and neither are you.”

“You weren’t meant to be a killer,” he replied coldly. “But I wasn’t meant to die that night either.”

She slammed the receiver down and screamed.

Screamed in utter terror.

Quietly, from the unplugged phone on the table, came one last message from David. “You need to do this, Lana, or else people will die.”

Her knees and arms began to shake.

Lana collapsed into the beanbag chair and ripped David’s flannel off her body.

That voice wasn’t just David’s. It was something so much darker now.

Chapter 16

August 2024

Lana pulled into her designated parking spot in front of her apartment and turned the engine off. Instead of leaving the car to go inside, she just sat there in her thoughts. The steering wheel was warm beneath her palms as she tapped her fingers there to try and get rid of some of the nerves.

Her eyes drifted to the third-floor window of their apartment. The curtains were drawn so she couldn't see inside, but she could picture it perfectly. The couch where they used to fall asleep watching movies. The kitchen counter where he used to make coffee every morning. The spot on the wall where the wine glass had shattered.

Where she had thrown that wine glass.

She felt sick thinking about it. She could still see the way his face had looked that night. Then her thoughts came rushing back in.

What if he'd already decided it was over? What if he only agreed to meet because he felt obligated? What if he opened the door, let her in, and things were just done?

Her eyes burned, but she blinked the tears away. She didn't want to walk in there already crying. Her phone sat in the cupholder beside her. She picked it up and unlocked it. There were no new messages or missed calls, just the same screen she'd been staring at all week.

Lana looked up from her lap and at the door. She imagined walking up the stairs, hearing his footsteps on the other side, the pause before he opened. But she couldn't imagine the look on his face.

Would he smile?

Would he look angry?

Her fingers started tapping again. A car drove past behind her, tires crunching over gravel. The sound startled her, pulling her out of her thoughts. She looked down at her trembling hands.

"Okay," she whispered to herself. "You can do this."

She grabbed her keys, then opened the car door. The cool air hit her face as she stepped out. Closing the door behind her, she stood for a moment in the street, looking up at their window. Then she started walking toward the entrance, heart pounding with every step.

As she approached the door, she fumbled to take her keys out of her pocket. She wondered if it was okay to enter without knocking. I mean, it was her house, but she hadn't lived in it in over three weeks. Before she could debate it anymore, David opened the door.

He gave her a soft smile. He looked tired and worn down. They stood there for a moment, awkward and unsure of what to say first.

"I'm glad you came," he finally said.

"Me too," she replied.

He gestured for Lana to come inside.

They sat on opposite ends of the couch at first, knees not touching, hands folded in their laps. Lana stared at the floor, then finally forced herself to look at him. They sat in silence for quite some time.

Finally, Lana took a breath. “I practiced this conversation in my head the whole drive here.”

David glanced up. “Did it go well in your head?”

She let out a little laugh. “Depends on the version.”

“Yeah. I’ve been doing that too.”

Silence entered the room again.

“I’m.. I’m sorry,” she said. “For the glass. For the way I talked to you. For leaving. David.. I.. I’m so sorry.” Tears already started to form.

David relaxed a little as if her words eased the tension in the room. “I’m sorry too.” His gaze shifted to his hands, woven together in his lap. “ I am sorry for standing there like an idiot that night,” he said. “For watching you instead of going to you. I keep thinking about it. Over and over and every time, I wish I’d just moved. Just walked across the room and held you.”

Lana swallowed. “I didn’t want you to see me like that.”

“I know,” he said softly. “But I still should have come to you. And I should have never blamed you. I just felt so broken.”

They both fell quiet again.

Lana blinked back more tears. “I thought you still blamed me.”

David’s head snapped up. “What? No.”

“I saw the way you looked at me,” she said quietly. “Like something had changed. Like I wasn’t the same person anymore.”

His expression crumpled. “I wasn’t looking at you like that. I was looking at myself. I kept thinking… maybe I should’ve taken you to the hospital sooner. Maybe I should’ve noticed something. Maybe I did something wrong. What I said, I didn’t mean that. ”

She shook her head. “You didn’t.”

“Of course not,” he said. “I don’t know who I even was that night. I was just shocked and angry at the world, and I blamed you when I should have been there for you.”

Lana wiped at her eyes. “I started drinking more because it was the only time I didn’t feel everything so loudly.”

He nodded slowly. “I noticed.”

“I know you did,” she said. “And I know it scared you.”

“It did,” he admitted. “Not because I thought you were some out-of-control person. But because I could see how much pain you were in, and I didn’t know how to reach you.”

She looked at him then, really looked at him. “Why didn’t you tell me that?”

He gave a small, sad smile. “Because I thought you already had enough on your plate. I didn’t want to add my feelings on top of yours.”

“That just made it lonelier,” she said.

“I know that now.”

“I didn’t leave because I stopped loving you,” Lana said.

David’s jaw tightened slightly. “Then why did you leave?”

She hesitated. “Because I was scared of what I was turning into. I didn’t like the person I was around you. I was mean. I was bitter. I was… cruel sometimes.”

“You weren’t cruel,” he said gently.

“I threw a glass at the wall, David.”

He shook his head. “You threw a glass at the wall. Not at me.”

She looked down. “I still hated who I was at that moment.”

He was quiet for a second. “I hated who I was, too. The guy who just stood there and watched his wife fall apart.”

They both let that settle.

“I thought maybe some space would help,” she said. “Help me calm down. Help us reset.”

“Did it?” he asked.

She thought about it. “A little. Being with my mom helped. She didn’t treat me like I was broken. Just… sad.”

David nodded. “I missed you. The apartment felt… empty.”

Lana’s throat tightened. “I missed you too.”

He looked at her carefully. “Do you still want this? Us, I mean.”

She didn’t hesitate. “Yes. I do. I just don’t want to keep hurting each other.”

“Neither do I.”

She shifted slightly closer on the couch, the space between them shrinking. “I know we can’t go back to the way things were before.”

“No,” he said. “But maybe we can figure out what comes next.”

She nodded. “I don’t want perfect. I just want honesty.”

“I can do honest,” he said. “Even when it’s ugly.”

She gave a small smile. “Especially when it’s ugly.”

They sat in silence for a moment, but this time it felt comfortable. Their knees brushed. Neither of them pulled away. Lana reached out, her fingers hovering before finally resting lightly on his hand. He didn't move at first, like he was afraid the moment would break. Then he turned his palm upward and laced his fingers through hers.

The contact was simple, but it felt like everything would be okay again.

They didn't rush the moment. They talked for hours, about grief and fear. They talked about how losing the baby had cracked something open in both of them and how neither of them knew how to close it. They admitted the things they hadn't wanted to say before.

That night, when the apartment went to sleep, Lana lay awake beside David, staring into the darkness. The bed felt the same. The mattress dipped the same way it always had. But everything else felt charged, as if this were a new chapter for them. Like this could be the fresh start they needed.

Lana rolled onto her side, facing him. She could just make out the outline of his face in the dark, the familiar slope of his nose, the shadow of his lashes. He was already watching her.

David reached out slowly, like he was giving her time to pull away, and brushed his thumb along her wrist. The touch was light, but it sent a shiver up her arm anyway. It had been so long since they'd touched like this without tension hanging over it.

"I missed you," she said quietly.

Something in his expression shifted. He moved closer, their knees brushing, his hand sliding from her wrist to her waist, so very gentle. Lana inhaled sharply at the familiarity of it, the way her body recognized his touch before her mind could catch up.

"I missed you too," he said, his voice lower now.

The first kiss was very careful. David leaned in slowly, his lips brushing against hers. Lana kissed him back, her hand curling into the fabric of his t-shirt. The kiss deepened naturally as David's hand slid up her back, losing its gentle touch and instead grabbing her firm and confident.

Lana kissed him again, this time with intent, her hand sliding up his chest, feeling the warmth beneath her palm. David responded immediately, rolling slightly toward her, his hand tightening at her waist, pulling her closer until there was no space left between them.

David paused, pulling back just enough to look at her. "Tell me if you want me to stop."

She shook her head, her voice barely above a whisper. "Don't."

They moved slowly, deliberately, every touch bringing them closer and closer. Lana let herself feel it all, the warmth of his skin, the way he held her like something precious, the way being close to him made her feel real again.

Afterward, they lay tangled together beneath the sheets, Lana's head resting on his chest, his hand tracing patterns along her arm. The room was quiet except for the sound of their breathing, synced once again without effort.

Chapter 17

November 2025

Lana thought she had never left the beanbag that night. The fairy lights above the ceiling still glowed faintly, and the words replayed over and over in her mind.

He needs to be killed.

That wasn't David. She knew David. She knew the way he spoke when he was upset, the way his voice would soften. The voice on the phone last night didn't sound like him. It couldn't have been.

Lana pulled the blanket tighter around her shoulders, her fingers curling into the fabric. Her body felt heavy, like she could sink all the way into the beanbag and disappear.

But every time her eyes drifted shut, the call replayed. Again and again. The way his voice changed. The way he said the name.

Jeremy Koss.

The name echoed in her head like it meant something to her, like it was important, but she knew no one by that name. Every time she tried to think about it too hard, her chest tightened. She glanced at the rotary phone again. It hadn't moved or made a sound. But yet, it felt both alive and like the center of the room.

The air in the library felt colder than usual. A faint draft brushed against her bare ankles. She pulled her feet closer to her body, turning herself into a little ball.

Did I leave a window open?

She couldn't remember.

She pressed her face into the teddy bear beside her. For a moment, she let herself imagine David sitting on the floor across from her like he used to. Back against the shelves. Book in hand.

"What if we recreated this scene?" he'd say, showing her a chapter of some dirty book he stole from her shelf.

"I wouldn't complain," she'd say with a flirtatious smile on her face.

"Oh yeah."

She squeezed her eyes shut, but the image didn't comfort her anymore, and the thought of his touch was no longer something she longed for.

Her stomach twisted again.

What if it wasn't him at all? What if something else is doing this?

The thought made her skin crawl, but an even worse one followed.

What if it really is him… and he's right?

She sat up slightly, the blanket slipping from her shoulders. She replayed his words again.

This needs to be done, or more people will get hurt.

Her heart pounded.

Who would get hurt? How and why her?

She wasn't strong or brave. She was definitely not someone who could hurt another person. She was barely holding herself together.

"I can't do this," she whispered. "I can't."

Her voice sounded so small in the quiet room. She pulled the blanket back around herself and curled deeper into the beanbag once again. Her hands trembled slightly in her lap. She stared at them without really thinking, noticing how dry they looked. A faint gray film clung to the creases of her knuckles and under her nails, like dust.

She rubbed her thumb across her palm. The skin felt rough. Slightly gritty. Weird, she thought distantly. I don't remember touching anything dusty. She wiped her hands against the blanket without much thought. The fabric picked up faint, smudgy streaks, but in the dim light, they barely showed. Her head felt foggy. Heavy. Like there were pieces of the night missing.

At some point, the darkness outside the window softened into a dull gray. Morning light seeped slowly into the room, flattening the shadows and making everything look alive again.

Lana didn't notice the morning arriving. She just sat there, eyes heavy but open, thoughts circling and circling.

It was just past 8:00 a.m. when she heard a knock on the door.

No whispering voice from beyond, no messages from the dead, just a knock. Soft and hesitant, like someone unsure if their presence was welcomed. Three gentle taps.

She gripped the bathrobe around her and rose to her feet with reluctant effort. Her muscles ached from staying still for so long, and her eyes blurred from the sleepless night. She walked sluggishly down the hallway toward the door, moving as slowly as if she were underwater.

She opened the door to see Mrs. Kent standing on the porch, wearing a dark brown raincoat over her brightly colored nightgown. Her hair was tied in a messy bun with gray wisps escaping and blowing gently in the morning wind. She leaned against her cane and looked like she hadn't slept that night either.

Mrs. Kent's lips were pursed, trembling as tears dripped down from her glassy eyes. She stepped forward, her cane making a faint tapping noise on the wooden porch as she moved closer. She reached to take Lana's hand into her own. Her old, weathered grip gave a gentle squeeze.

Lana's stomach turned cold.

"I didn't want you to hear from the news," Mrs. Kent said slowly. Her voice trembled like a flame caught in a light breeze. "I wanted you to hear from a friend."

Lana took a deep breath, accepting that whatever she was going to hear, she would not like.

“What is it?”

Mrs. Kent swallowed as she struggled to keep eye contact. Her eyes darted around the room as if they were looking for any possible way to soften the truth.

“There was a fire,” she finally said. “At Charlotte’s building. It started around 2:00 this morning. The fire department said it spread… it spread too fast. They tried. They tried, and nothing could have been done.”

Lana blinked slowly, the words not registering. She was numb at this point.

“No,” she pleaded. “That’s not possible. Charlotte is the smartest and strongest person I know. She would have gotten out.”

“I’m so sorry, Lana.” Mrs. Kent’s hand gripped Lana’s even tighter. “I’m so sorry. They confirmed it an hour ago. She didn’t make it.”

She took a step back, letting her hand escape Mrs. Kent’s grip and drop to her side. “No,” she repeated. “She was just here. She made me cookies. She was… She was just fine.”

Mrs. Kent couldn’t hold herself together anymore. She began to cry. Not for herself, but for what she had seen Lana go through.

“What about Stephanie and the kids? Are they okay?”

“They are okay,” the old lady said. “They were out of town at a soccer tournament.”

Lana sighed with some relief, then returned to the reality of the situation. The reality that she lost her best friend.

“Umm… well, thanks for letting me know,” she said with perfect clarity. Her brain was running too fast to truly comprehend the situation.

“Lana, please let me know if you need anything. I am always here for you.”

With a polite smile, she retreated back into her apartment and let the door close behind her with an echoing thud. The sounds around her seemed louder than ever. The beeping of the smoke alarm. The ticking of the clock. The rustling of her bedroom curtains. The silence of the rotary phone sitting on that desk.

Her thoughts finally caught up with her and consumed her. Charlotte was gone. Her best friend. Her only friend.

This isn’t real. It can’t be.

The one person who was always there for me. The one person who let me cry every night for weeks after David’s death. It’s just gone.

I am completely alone now. Alone.

At that very moment, something within Lana switched. Her legs buckled beneath her, and she dropped onto the hallway floor. Not in grief anymore, but in rage as she remembered what was said on the phone last night. What David had told her.

“This needs to be done, or more people will get hurt.”

This was her fault. She knew it. If she had just listened, this would have never happened. The rage lit such a fire within her that she swore she could smell the smoke emerging from her ears.

This was all my fault.

At that very moment, Lana knew what she had to do.

Chapter 18

February 2025

“Hell no!” Lana shouted, clutching a wad of fake orange bills to her chest. “You are not charging me rent, sir.”

David leaned back in his chair, fanning his wad of cash like he was the Bill Gates of the Upper West Side. “Marriage does not protect you from capitalism. Sorry, babe.”

She narrowed her eyes. “You sound like a villain.”

“I am the villain tonight, and you just landed on Boardwalk, so pay up.”

She gasped. “You’re evil.”

“That’ll be $2,000, please.”

“This is emotional abuse,” Lana said with a slightly worried tone.

“You chose the dog,” he said, pointing at the silver Scottish terrier wagging its tail, unbeknownst to the fact that it had just landed on his property. “The dog always loses.”

“The dog is adorable,” she shot back. “I stand by my choice.”

He watched her count out the money with exaggerated slowness, lips twitching as he tried not to laugh. She threw a single dollar at him. “Take it and choke.”

“You’re very aggressive. You are just going bankrupt and may have to go live on the streets for a while. What’s the big deal?”

She leaned forward, eyes narrowing. “Don’t get cocky, mister. I still have Park Place.”

“Park Place is nothing without Boardwalk.”

“Just like you’re nothing without me,” she shot back.

He placed a hand dramatically over his heart. “That was almost romantic. I thought you weren’t silly like that.”

“Almost,” she said.

They sat there for a moment with the board between them. The late afternoon sunlight spilled across the living room floor. The apartment smelled faintly like the Chinese takeout they’d eaten earlier. The TV was on in the background, replaying Friends for the hundredth time.

David reached across the board and flicked her knee with his toe.

She jerked back. “Hey. That’s just weird.”

“You’re thinking too hard,” he said. “It’s a game.”

“It’s not just a game. It’s a psychological war. This proves who is dating down, and we all know you are the one dating way out of your league.”

He grinned. “Then consider yourself defeated.”

She stared at him for a long moment. Then, without warning, she lunged forward and knocked the board sideways. Money scattered everywhere, and the dog token flew off the table and landed near the couch.

David blinked. “Hey, I haven’t won yet!”

She grabbed his shirt and pulled him toward her. “I’m declaring bankruptcy.”

He laughed. “That’s not how this works.”

“It is now.”

She kissed him before he could argue further. He let out a surprised sound against her mouth, then kissed her back, hands sliding around her waist. Her eyes were closed, but she could feel his smile against her lips. The Monopoly money fluttered to the floor around their feet.

“You’re a sore loser,” he murmured.

“You love it.”

He smiled against her lips. “I really do.”

She pulled back just enough to look at him. “Come on.”

“Come on, where?”

She glanced toward the hallway. “Closet.”

He raised an eyebrow. “Again?”

She grinned. “It’s tradition.”

“We do have a perfectly good bedroom.”

“Too obvious.”

“The couch?”

“Too predictable.”

He gave a dramatic sigh and pretended like he wasn’t excited. “Fine, but if I knock over the vacuum again, it’s your fault.”

She grabbed his hand and dragged him down the hallway, both of them laughing quietly like teenagers sneaking around their parents’ house.

Halfway there, he pulled her back toward him, wrapping his arms around her waist and kissing her in the doorway.

“You’re trouble,” he said.

The next morning, the apartment still smelled faintly like the takeout they’d eaten the night before. Soy sauce and garlic hung in the air, intertwining with the smell of lavender laundry detergent. The Monopoly board was still crooked on the coffee table, and colorful paper speckled the room.

Lana woke to sunlight stretching across the ceiling and the sound of robins chirping. She had a feeling that today was going to be a good day. She felt at home with her cheek pressed against David's shoulder and his arm over her waist. She watched as his chest moved up and down, matching the sound of his breath.

"You're staring," he mumbled, eyes still closed.

"Now how would you know that?" Lana said, smiling.

"Because you are obsessed with me."

She sighed and then began to plead. "Stay home today," she said. "Call in sick."

He frowned. "Why? Just because you don't have to work on Saturdays doesn't mean I don't have to."

"So we can finish the Monopoly game."

He snorted. "You flipped the board. That was a resignation."

"That was a strategic, and temporary, withdrawal."

He stretched, then rolled out of bed with a groan. "I have a meeting at ten. If I don't go, Mark will send me passive-aggressive emails for a week."

"Worth it," she said.

He pulled on a T-shirt and ran a hand through his hair. "You're a bad influence."

"You married me."

He smiled. “Best decision I ever made.”

He leaned down and kissed her forehead, lingering for a second longer than usual.

“I’ll be back before dinner,” he said.

“Okay.”

“Don’t start the next episode without me.”

“No promises.”

He grabbed his keys from the bowl near the door, then turned back.

“Love you,” he said.

“Love you too.”

He gave her a toothless smile, then stepped out into the hallway. The door shut behind him with a soft click. Lana lay there for a moment and listened to his footsteps fade down the hallway.

She eventually got up, padding into the kitchen in her socks. The coffee maker gurgled to life. She stepped over the scattered Monopoly money, shaking her head.

“Disaster zone,” she muttered to herself.

She picked up the dog token from the floor and set it back on the board.

“Come on, buddy,” she said quietly. “We’ll get our revenge tonight.”

She poured herself a cup of coffee and stood by the window, watching cars pass on the street below. Everything felt normal, peaceful, and safe.

Her phone buzzed on the counter.

BUZZ BUZZ

Unknown number.

She ignored it and rested her phone back down on the table. It rang again.

BUZZ BUZZ

She picked it up with a heavy sigh. “Hello?”

“Is this Lana Davis?” The voice was formal.

“Yes.”

“This is Officer Gray with the county police department. I’m calling in regard to your husband, David Johnson.”

Her grip tightened around the phone. “What about him?” There was a pause. Just long enough for her heart to start pounding.

“He was involved in a motor vehicle accident about twenty minutes ago.”

The room felt suddenly smaller. The walls were closing in on her. “Is he okay?” she asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

Another pause. Longer this time. And in that silence, she knew. “I’m very sorry, ma’am,” the officer said. “He didn’t survive the impact.”

The mug slipped from her hand and shattered against the tile. Coffee spread across the floor. “No,” she whispered. “No, that’s not… no. That’s not possible. I just… he just left.”

“I’m so sorry,” the voice repeated.

Her knees gave out, and she sank to the floor among the broken pieces of ceramic and spilled coffee.

The apartment was still. The Monopoly board sat on the table. The dog token was waiting on its square. The fake money was scattered, as if expecting someone to come back and finish the game. They had fixed it. They had started this new chapter together. Everything was amazing. But now it was just gone. Like that. It was all gone.

Chapter 19

November 2025

The sky was a heavy gray, seeming to tear as rain escaped and painted the city roads in a glistening ebony. Water slid down the windows of the neighboring buildings, blurring the world into little smudges. The gutters below gurgled as they swallowed the downpour.

Inside the apartment, Lana sat at the small kitchen table with the old phone book spread open in front of her. Its pages were yellowed and soft from years of use. The corners were bent and dog-eared. David had insisted on keeping it even after they moved in together because “the internet could break,” which she just went along with.

Her fingers moved slowly down the columns of names, scanning hundreds of strangers. Some last names were scratched out in pen, while others were circled. She never realized how much David had used this book until now.

The pages made a dry, papery sound each time she turned them. She finally got to the K section, and there were three people with the name Jeremy Koss. First, a dentist. She felt that seemed unlikely, as he had been in practice for forty-seven years, and this did not seem like an old man’s crime. Next was a florist. She immediately skipped over that one. And then, like brakes slamming in a car, her hand stopped.

There it was.

KOSS, JEREMY

MOSS & OAK BAR — UPTOWN

Thurs–Sun | 7 p.m.–2 a.m.

This was her target, and she was certain of it. This was the man whose name had been whispered through the phone. The man who was somehow tied to everything that had happened. She knew it in her soul.

He needs to be killed.

The words echoed in her mind as rain tapped steadily against the window. Her chair scraped on the floor as she stood. The phone book remained open on the table, the name staring up at the ceiling.

She didn't remember making the decision to leave. She didn't remember walking into the bedroom or pulling open the back drawer of the dresser. She didn't remember pushing aside old receipts, knotted chargers, and the faded RV park map from their camping trip in Key West last summer.

But somehow, the blade was now in her hand. It was the same one David had used to cut rope and open food packages during the trip. The metal still had a light blue stain from when they cut open a blueberry pie. She didn't remember putting it into her coat pocket. She didn't remember slipping on her shoes, grabbing her keys from the bowl by the door, or pulling the door open.

But she did remember the rain.

Chapter 20

November 2025

The windshield wipers of her sedan slid in smooth arcs. The city around her was a blur, yet she knew exactly where she was going, as if intuition was guiding her. The red taillights smeared along her fogged window like blood across glass. She gripped the steering wheel so hard that her knuckles began to glow white.

She drove in silence. No radio. Just the sound of her wheels skipping along the puddles. David's commands kept echoing in her ears, tuning out the city sounds around her.

“You weren’t meant to be a killer… But I wasn’t meant to die that night either.”

She didn’t recognize her own reflection in the rearview mirror. Her eyes were sunken, lips cracked, and smile dead. A woman broken by more tragedies than anyone should ever have to go through. A woman who had once been the light in every room she walked into, now burnt out like a candle finally out of wax.

Like a mirage through the downpour, Moss and Oak appeared. Its neon sign blinked crimson and gold, reflected across the slick sidewalk like spilled merlot. The bar was a time capsule. Vines grew up the cracked brick wall, and paint peeled from the window trim like faded wallpaper curling only to reveal the surface beneath. A metal awning stuck out from the side, with a wooden chair underneath for when employees chose to take smoke breaks.

She circled the building over and over until she decided to park two blocks away in the art museum parking lot. A place she used to go to relax after what she felt were hard days, but now they just seemed like childish and pathetic excuses to have ever been sad.

The rain soaked Lana's hair in seconds. The strands clung to her cheeks and the back of her neck. She stood beside the open car door for a moment, one hand still gripping its metal edge. The air was cold, and the smell of rain was overwhelming. Her boots met the pavement with a dull smack, the sound swallowed quickly by the storm.

You can still leave.

The thought came in like an angel on her shoulder.

Get back in the car. Drive home. Pretend you never came.

Her heart thudded harder. But then another voice, a darker voice.

You know what you have to do. For David.

Her fingers curled into fists at her sides. Rain slid down her temples and into her shirt. She felt the cold water drip down onto her chest. She lifted her face slightly toward the sky, letting the water hit her closed eyelids.

This is what he wants. This is what has to happen.

She swallowed, tasting rain and something metallic.

You weren't meant to be a killer.

Her jaw tightened. No.

I wasn't meant to be a widow either.

Her boots struck the sidewalk, each step acting like a meteorite, extinguishing the puddles around it. Each one brought her closer to the neon glow at the end of the block. She knew he should be there, as long as the ad hadn't changed.

She approached the side of the bar, knife tucked into her jacket pocket, and her heart stopped as she saw him standing beneath the metal canopy.

Chapter 21

November 2025

The rain struck the metal canopy like the sounds of war drums. The neon sign from the street bled a faint red into the alley. Its light flickered every few seconds to reveal Jeremy standing beneath the awning.

Alone.

He was tall, mid-thirties, and had black stubble that barely showed through his brown hoodie. He pressed one heel lazily against the brick behind him and had a cigarette burning between his fingers, its ember flaring each time he inhaled. He scrolled through his phone, lips twitching into quiet bursts of laughter. Every few seconds, his thumb moved again, dismissing whatever had amused him seconds earlier.

There was something unbearable about how ordinary he looked. The curve of his mouth. The way he shifted his weight from one foot to the other. The absentminded flick of ash from his cigarette. These were not the gestures of a monster, but of a man ending a shift and killing some time before going home.

Lana stood at the edge of the rain, just beyond the shelter of the canopy. Her coat clung to her shoulders. Her boots felt heavier with each passing second. She didn't need to ask his name. She knew it the way you know the last line of a song that's been stuck in your head for weeks.

She knew in her heart that this was the man. This was the man who killed her husband.

Her hand tightened inside her coat pocket around the knife. The metal pressed cold and solid into her palm. She stepped forward as the rain followed her into the alley.

“Jeremy.”

He looked up immediately, confused about who could be interrupting him at this hour. He pulled the cigarette from his mouth and squinted through the rain. For a second, his face was blank. Then something shifted. His eyes narrowed slightly in recognition.

“…Right,” he said under his breath. He slipped his phone into his pocket slowly, buying himself a moment. He straightened off the wall, adjusting his stance. “It’s you,” he said.

Lana’s pulse quickened. “You don’t know me,” she said.

He tilted his head slightly, studying her face as if comparing it to a memory he hadn’t expected to use again. “I’ve seen you,” he said carefully. “A few times.”

The words hit her like a misstep in the dark. A part of her plan that she never factored in.

“No,” she replied automatically. “You haven’t.”

He hesitated. Just a fraction of a second. Long enough to show he was choosing not to argue.

“Okay,” he said evenly. “Maybe I’m mixing you up.”

He threw his cigarette onto the ground and smashed the glowing bud with his boot. He locked eyes with Lana once again, clearly annoyed with her presence. “You shouldn’t be out here,” he added. “It’s late.” The casualness of it scraped against her nerves.

“You killed him,” she said.

The words fell into the alley and seemed to stay there. Jeremy let out a comedic laugh; his jaw tightened slightly. “Killed who?”

“David.” The name echoed through the alley.

For a moment, he didn’t answer. His gaze searched her face again, slower this time. “You mentioned your husband before,” he continued. “You said he died.”

“Stop,” she said.

He didn’t move closer or away, but his posture shifted. He grabbed another cigarette from his pocket.

“You came in upset,” he said. “A couple of nights.”

Her mind searched for the memory and found only fog. Not only was he a killer, but he was a liar too.

“I’ve never met you,” she insisted.

His eyes held hers. “Okay,” he said gently.

Smoke from his cigarette curled upward between them, thin and ghostlike in the damp air. For a moment, it twisted into shapes her mind wanted to recognize. A face. She swore David was standing just behind him. Like a ghost made out of smoke, reminding her of why she came there and what she had to do.

Her heartbeat roared in her ears. “You killed him,” she repeated. More confident this time. David’s shadow seemed to smile behind him only to be blown away by the evening winds.

Jeremy let out a sigh and began to step out into the rain toward Lana. “I didn’t kill anyone,” he said. “I think you need to…”

Her hand moved before the sentence finished. The knife slid free from her coat pocket, catching a pulse of red neon light from the sign at the mouth of the alley. The blade gleamed for only a second before the rain dulled it.

Jeremy froze. His eyes dropped to the knife, then back to her face. This was no longer funny to him.

“Okay,” he said carefully. “Let’s not do this, Lana. Put it down.” He took a slow step backward, the brick wall at his back now.

The way he said her name made something twist inside her chest. He knew her name.

“Let’s talk about this,” he continued carefully. “This is all some type of misunderstanding.”

Understanding just felt like an insult. Rain hammered all around them.

“I loved him more than anything, Jeremy.” She began to walk closer to him, his body trapped between the brick wall and a dark green dumpster. “And you took him away from me.”

At that very moment, something within Lana Davis snapped. Once a calm and quiet girl who loved to read books and play Monopoly, she found a vicious side of herself that no one may have thought possible.

Steel moved in the blink of an eye.

“Wait…” he choked.

The first strike landed with a shocking thud. Jeremy gasped in disbelief as he looked down at the blade in his chest.

The blade that sat in the center of his chest.

Deep in his chest.

She looked down in shock, hands trembling, but continued her slaughter.

Lana pulled the knife out from inside him. The rain immediately thinned the blood, but not enough to drown it out. He staggered backward into the wall, sliding slightly as red smeared against the brick.

“Lana,” he rasped, confusion breaking into fear. His hand caught her wrist weakly, more reflex than defense. “I didn’t…” he tried, but the words broke apart.

She struck again. His phone slipped from his pocket and shattered on the pavement.

“Please,” he said, barely audible.

The storm swallowed the word. He slid down the wall slowly until his back met the ground. His eyes remained open, searching her face. Trying to understand.

She struck again.

Again.

Again.

Again.

Until all she could hear was the rain.

She stood above him with the knife in her hand. The neon sign flickered again, bleeding red across the wet pavement. The city kept humming somewhere beyond the alley, yet the voice in her head was gone.

She dropped the knife. It clattered against the ground beside him and fell into the sewer below.

Jeremy lay stuck between a brick wall and a dumpster, eyes open and lifeless, a smear of blood tracing his final moments of life. The glowing embers of his cigarette finally went black.

Chapter 22

November 2025

By the time Lana reached her apartment building, the rain had turned into a cold mist. Her jeans clung to her legs, and her sweater was so heavy it weighed her down. She did not remember crossing the last intersection or turning the last corner. The world simply rearranged itself around her until she was home.

She closed the door of her car and gazed along her empty street. Her legs trembled slightly. On her doorstep, she gripped the porch railing too tightly and had to consciously relax her fingers. She became suddenly aware of her hands and what they had just done. When she finally reached her apartment door, she fumbled with her keys. It took her three attempts to fit the right one into the lock. The door opened with a click, and she stepped inside quickly, closing it behind her. She locked it once. Then again, just to make sure.

As she slid the chain across, she rested her back against the door with a wet thud. Her wet clothes were trapped between the hardwood behind her and her goosebumped skin, dripping the fallen rain onto the floor.

For a second, she just stood there in silence, eyes closed. All that could be heard were the sounds of her heavy breathing and the rain trickling down into the drains outside. She was trying to ground herself. Trying to calm herself down. With each and every breath, her heart rate began to lower, and the dripping of the rain on the wooden floor became less frequent.

After some time, she opened her eyes and began to move toward the bathroom. Without turning on any lights, she walked through the living room with a newfound level of quietness. She walked past the wall where she threw the glass. Past the kitchen where she destroyed the first phone. She walked past the library and the grandmother clock, its face seeming to watch her. Finally, she arrived in the bedroom and locked eyes with her bed. The bed that was suited for two, but now just housed her.

Lana put down her jacket on the chair next to the bed and walked toward the bathroom. The overhead light reflected against the pearly white tiles framed by the rough, gray grout. The humming of the pipes welcomed her in.

She gripped the edge of the sink and looked down at her hands. There was dried blood beneath her nails, dark and encased in the small half-moons of her cuticles. A thin, nearly invisible line ran along the inside of her wrist where the rain failed to reach. She had expected to be covered in blood, but she wasn't. The rain had washed any evidence of her night away.

She turned on the faucet and put her hands beneath the stream. The water ran clear at first. She scrubbed and scrubbed, scratching her palms and digging the blood out from under her nails. Pink clouds swirled faintly down the drain. She kept washing long after there was nothing left. Her reflection in the mirror looked pale and dead.

She showered next, standing under water that was much too hot. The heat reddened her skin and fogged the mirror. As the water ran over her shoulders, her mind began to wander. She realized how her timeline had blurred. She remembered not sleeping and staring at the ceiling. She remembered the first call at 1:43 a.m. and the way her heart had nearly stopped when she

heard David's voice through the speaker. But the hours between those moments dissolved when she tried to examine them. She could not clearly account for every evening. Her memories began to feel like a blur.

The water began to cool, but she did not move. She just watched the water turn lighter and lighter shades of pink until nothing remained.

When she finally stepped out and dressed in clean clothes, she spotted a final drop of blood. It stuck out against the white floor. Its bright color looked similar to a speck of paint, and its perfect round shape could be mistaken for a small ladybug. She carefully grabbed a piece of toilet paper from the wall and wiped the floor clean.

She walked into the bedroom and sat on the edge of the bed. The digital clock on her nightstand read 1:39 a.m.

Her stomach tightened. Every night for the last week, the phone had rung at 1:43 a.m. without fail. Her pulse accelerated as she stared at her phone. She believed that if Jeremy was the right man, the calls should stop. The logic seemed simple enough. The task was complete. Her thoughts began to fracture into millions of possibilities.

What if there were no calls?

What if there was no murderer?

What if she filled in the gaps herself because grief could not tolerate ambiguity?

The second hand clicked into place, and she held her breath. Then…

Nothing.

1:44 a.m.

The phone remained still as silence stretched across the room. Ten seconds passed. Then twenty. Then thirty. The longer it lasted, the more unbearable it became. She had braced for relief, for a feeling of freedom. But instead, she felt alone and hollow.

Her gaze drifted toward the bedroom doorway. The apartment beyond was dark. For a brief moment, she imagined David standing there. Lana lay back against the mattress, staring at the ceiling. She turned her head slightly toward the nightstand, watching the digital clock glow steadily in the darkness. 1:58 a.m. A small, tight sense of satisfaction settled into her chest.

She let her eyes close, but sleep did not come. Her mind drifted back to the alley, whether she invited it to or not. The rain had been relentless, pouring down so hard it blurred everything. Jeremy had stepped back when she approached him. He had known her name and said it.

The memory did not fracture under examination. When he had looked at her, there had been something in his expression. She had interpreted it as guilt then, and she interpreted it as guilt now. The human face betrays what the mouth refuses to confess. His eyebrows had drawn together, his lips parting as if he were scrambling for an explanation he hadn't prepared. She had seen that look before. It was the look of a liar.

She rolled onto her side and pulled the blanket tighter around herself. Beneath the relief she felt, something was stirring. It was not doubt. No. She refused to name it that. Doubt implied uncertainty or that she might have been wrong. The calls had been real. The voice had been real.

Killing Jeremy was what she was supposed to do. She was not crazy. She knew that. She just had something crazy happen to her.

Yes. That was it.

Just before she drifted off to sleep, a final image surfaced: Jeremy's face in the rain, illuminated briefly by a passing car's headlights. His mouth was open, forming words she had not let him finish.

Lana's eyes fluttered open for a moment, staring into the dark. It didn't matter what he had been about to say. He was a liar and a murderer who didn't deserve a final goodbye.

That night, at 1:43 a.m., the phone had remained silent. That night was the best night of sleep Lana Davis had gotten in nine months.

Chapter 23

December 2025

A month later, the city had settled back into its ordinary rhythm, and so had Lana. Nights had grown quiet, and she slept through them now. Work deadlines approached and were met. Groceries were bought. The laundry was folded. She spoke to colleagues about weekend plans, weather forecasts, or even the last episode of their favorite dating show. She was the happiest she had been since the accident.

On an early Monday morning, Lana sat at a corner table alone, clutching her warm tea and typing away on her computer. The café buzzed with the sounds of daily rituals. She listened to the clinking of ceramic mugs, the hiss of the steam wand releasing a burst of hot vapor, murmurs of conversations, and the occasional scrape of wooden chairs on tile floors. The room smelled of fresh coffee beans and the cologne of white-collared men heading to work in the busy city.

Outside, the rain had stopped, finally allowing the sun to peer through. Cars plowed through the flooded streets, creating miniature waves and honking every couple of seconds to rush the car in front of them.

Lana’s eyes drifted away from her project report and locked with those of a tall blonde gentleman. His eyes were so gorgeous, framed with espresso-colored glasses. His muscles peeked through his silk top just enough to show he was fit. His smile was contagious and could light up a whole room. Lana's cheeks began to flush.

She had seen this guy for the past two weeks now. He came in to order a hot chai tea latte with whole milk. She had decided last night that today would be the day she talked to him.

Lana closed her computer and delicately put it in her suitcase. She gathered her bag and walked over to his circular table.

Before she could get there, the door chimed sharply, and silence engulfed the café. Two men stepped inside, letting the squeaking of their wet boots echo. Their dark uniforms bore badges that shone in the overhead light, but their expressions were unreadable.

They scanned the room and announced, “Lana Davis?”

Lana rose to face the officers. She was not ashamed of what she had done; she did what was right. They would understand. Who wouldn’t?

“Yes?” she questioned.

The taller of the two approached her, his hands reaching into his pockets. The other officer kept his gun close and ready to use if need be. In a swift motion, the taller officer’s strong hands closed around her wrists.

“Lana Davis,” he repeated, glancing down briefly before looking back at her. “You are under arrest for the homicide of Jeremy Koss.”

A ripple moved through the café. The look on her mystery man’s face turned white, but Lana did not flinch. Homicide sounded so clinical to her. It did not reflect the necessity of that night.

She lifted her chin slightly. “There must be some mistake,” she said evenly, though her voice carried no panic.

The second officer moved closer now, positioning himself just behind her left shoulder. Close enough that she could feel his presence without turning her head. The taller officer stepped behind her. “Place your hands behind your back.”

Lana complied without resistance. She set her bag down carefully on the table beside her and moved her arms behind her, wrists crossing neatly. The officer’s hands were firm but not rough as they closed around her wrists. The metal of the handcuffs was cold and unforgiving as they snapped shut. The sound echoed in her ears.

A murmur began to rise around them, whispers weaving through the café like smoke. Someone reached for their phone to take a picture. A chair scraped harshly against the floor.

“You have the right to remain silent,” the officer recited, his voice steady and practiced. “Anything you say can and will be used against you in a court of law…”

She found herself staring at the condensation ring her tea had left on the wooden table as they guided her toward the door. The morning sun hit her eyes as they stepped outside. A horn blared somewhere down the block.

They led her down the steps and toward the patrol car parked along the curb. Neighbors had begun to gather at their windows. The blonde man had followed as far as the doorway of the café. For a brief moment, Lana’s gaze met his.

She allowed herself a small, composed inhale as the officer opened the back door of the car. She lowered herself into the seat carefully, the cuffs biting slightly into her skin as she adjusted. The door shut with a thud.

Through the tinted glass, she watched the café grow smaller as the car pulled away. The sun continued to shine against the wet pavement, bright and indifferent. She knew once she explained, they would understand. Why wouldn't they?

Chapter 24

December 2025

The inside of the station was colored like dried sage and smelled of old paper. The walls were that kind of green that reminded her of a hospital room. Not the kind covered in flowers to welcome a new life into this world, but a place where people went to die.

The fluorescent lights buzzed above, clashing with the noise of the handcuffs clinking behind her back. They walked down a narrow hallway, shoes leaving faint prints on the tile from the wet streets they had trudged through to get there. She kept her eyes low, counting the tiles as she was led to a small windowless room. With a quick shove and the sound of a closing steel door, she was locked inside.

Within the room, there was a steel table and two metal chairs. A single camera in the corner blinked red, reminding her of that smoke alarm in her bedroom.

She sat down slowly, hands resting on the cold tabletop. Across from her, the chair remained unoccupied. She was alone once again.

She thought of the conversation she was about to have. How some detective would hear her story and understand what she did. What she had to do. But no one came.

She sat in the cold chair for what felt like hours. Looking up at the wall, she watched the second hand make its journey around and around the clock. But nothing changed; she sat alone.

After what felt like an eternity, the metal door creaked open, and a woman entered. She was tall but strongly built. From the badge clipped to her belt, Lana determined that she was a detective. Late fifties, salt-and-pepper hair, she walked in carrying a thick manila folder.

"Ms. Davis," the woman said as she pulled out the chair. "I am Detective Marlow."

Lana nodded back confidently and let out a light smile. "Nice to meet you, Detective. This should be really quick, as this was all a big misunderstanding."

Like she didn't even hear her, Marlow continued, "Jeremy Koss is dead. Found around midnight a couple of weeks ago behind Moss and Oak. You want to tell me what happened?" Her voice was steady, without tone. She opened the file in front of her and wasted no time.

Lana's eyes gazed at the folder, then locked onto Marlow. "Well, I had to do it. He told me what I had to do."

"Who's he?"

Lana glanced toward the blinking light. "David."

Marlow blinked once and replied, "Your husband?"

"Yes."

"You mean the husband who has been dead for ten months?"

Lana grabbed the handcuffs in front of her, irritated. "He called me. Over and over. Always at the same time. He told me who did it. He told me who killed him. It was Jeremy. Jeremy killed my husband. I had to do it."

Marlow shifted in her seat. “I have your phone records here. You never got any calls at that time of night in the last month. There were no calls. No mysterious voice. No dead husbands whispering sweet murder messages through a dead phone. Lana, you killed someone. Do you understand that? It's not like you just fixed a small problem.”

Lana started to become anxious. This was not in her plan. She was supposed to understand. “No, you aren’t hearing me. Jeremy killed my husband. Jeremy is why Charlotte is dead. He is behind all the bad things that have been happening. If I hadn’t removed him from this world, more people would have died. I did a good thing.”

“Look at these, Lana.” Marlow pushed the manila folder toward her. “You haven’t been getting calls at night. The phone records say so. So why did you kill Jeremy? Did he say something to you?”

Lana looked down at the phone records. “I never met Jeremy before last night. David called me. He told me to do it. These must be fake.”

“No, Lana, these are very real. You want the truth?” Marlow leaned forward and looked Lana in the eyes. “Here is the truth. You knew Jeremy Koss. You have been going to that bar for months. Every night you ordered a Whiskey Sour, and he would serve it to you while you yapped about how much you hated your job and how hard life had been without David. He kicked you out three nights ago.” She slid another folder in front of her. “You became aggressive enough to be taken into custody for the night. And then you came back for revenge before the restraining order was even fully filed.”

Lana tried to dig deep into her memories, but this story was all foreign to her. “No. No. I’ve never met him before.” She opened the folder and found what seemed to her like a fairytale.

There was a police report with an image of her mugshot attached. An image of a napkin with M&O that the police had found at her apartment. Receipts from the bar using her credit card. An image of her sitting at the bar in one of her favorite outfits. But nothing even looked familiar to her. She knew they were fake.

“These can’t be real. I have never been there before. This man killed my husband, Detective. Why would I go to his bar?”

The detective let out a sigh. “No, he didn’t, Lana. The guy who killed your husband is in custody. You know that. He turned himself in. We have witnesses, dashcam footage, and the case was closed months ago. You wanted someone else to blame for your grief, and you picked Jeremy.”

Lana began to cry. “You don’t know what you are talking about. I am not crazy. The calls were real.” She pulled the handcuffs closer to her, and they created a loud clinging noise that echoed throughout the room, making Marlow jump.

“Maybe I don’t.” Marlow leaned back into her chair. “But I do know what arson looks like.”

“Arson?” Lana said, confused.

“Your fingerprints are all over the lighter we pulled from behind your so-called ‘best friend’s’ apartment. The fire started in her bedroom, and you were the last one seen leaving her apartment that night.”

She slid Lana a group of images. The first was of her wrapped up in David’s flannel, leaving Charlotte’s apartment at 2:00 a.m. The next was of her at a gas station buying a lighter and a tank of gasoline. And the last one made her heart drop. It was of Charlotte, but not her beautiful smile, rather her charred, dead body.

“You burned her alive. Your best friend,” Marlow said, her gaze drifting away from that last image as if even she couldn’t bear to look at it.

Lana felt like she was going to be sick. The room tilted slightly, the fluorescent lights too bright now, buzzing louder than before. “That wasn’t me. I loved her. I’m a good person. I would never hurt those around me.”

Marlow didn’t respond right away. She studied Lana’s face, as if searching for something beneath those tears. For a moment, the hard edge in her expression softened, the lines around her eyes relaxed, and her shoulders seemed to drop just slightly.

“Do you remember the night of the fire?” she asked quietly.

Lana shook her head, more urgently this time. “I remember being sad. I remember missing David. That’s all. I would never hurt Charlotte. She was my best friend. I loved her.” Her voice cracked on the last word, the memory of her friend surfacing. Memories of cookies in the kitchen, late-night talks, and comforting hugs.

Marlow nodded once and closed the folder gently. Her fingers lingered on the edge of the manila paper as if she were deciding something.

“Grief makes people do things they never thought they were capable of,” she said. “It doesn’t always look like crying in the shower or staring at old pictures. Sometimes it looks like anger. Sometimes it looks like an obsession. Sometimes it looks like fire.”

Lana’s tears fell harder now, dripping onto the steel table. They spread into small, uneven puddles beneath her hands. “I’m not a monster,” she whispered.

Marlow didn’t stand right away this time. Instead, she leaned back in her chair, studying Lana again, but differently now. Not like she was talking to a murderer, but a victim.

“Lana,” she said more softly, “do you really believe David was calling you?”

Lana looked up immediately, eyes wide, almost offended by the question. “I don’t just believe it. I know it. He called every night. Same time. Same voice. It was him.”

Marlow watched her carefully. “And no one else heard these calls?”

“They weren’t supposed to,” Lana said, as if it were obvious. “They were for me.”

“And the records being empty,” Marlow continued, “that doesn’t seem strange to you?”

Lana’s brow furrowed. “Of course it does. That’s why someone must have tampered with them. Jeremy probably knew someone. People like him always know someone.”

The certainty in her voice was unshaken. There was no hesitation, no flicker of doubt. It wasn’t the stubbornness of someone lying. It was the calm, solid conviction of someone who

truly believed what she was saying. Something in Marlow's expression changed then. The suspicion drained out of her eyes, replaced by something like pity.

"Did David ever tell you to hurt Charlotte?" Marlow asked gently.

Lana's head snapped up. "No. Never. I would never hurt Charlotte. She was my best friend."

Marlow nodded slowly. "But she died in a fire. A fire you were at. A fire where your fingerprints were found on the lighter. And you don't remember any of it."

Lana shook her head, tears spilling over. "No. That's wrong. That's not how it happened. Someone is lying to you."

Marlow inhaled slowly, then exhaled through her nose. She had seen this before. Different names, different crimes, but the same vacant certainty. The same fractured memory.

She closed the top folder and slid it away from Lana, as if the photographs inside were no longer meant for her to see.

"Lana," she said quietly, "I don't think you're lying to me."

Lana blinked, confused. "Then why am I here?"

"Because people are dead," Marlow replied. "And you were the last person with them."

Lana's lip trembled. "But I didn't mean to hurt anyone."

Marlow's voice softened further. "I believe you."

For the first time since the interrogation began, Lana's shoulders dropped. The tension in her body loosened slightly, like someone had cracked a window in a suffocating room.

"I just wanted it to stop hurting," she whispered. "Everywhere I looked, it was him. His clothes. His books. The clock. The stupid green light on the smoke detector. And the calls…"

Marlow swallowed. "And killing Jeremy felt like fixing it?"

Lana nodded weakly. "I thought… if I just got rid of the thing that was poisoning everything, maybe the world would go back to normal. Maybe he would finally rest."

The detective sat there for a long moment, saying nothing. The fluorescent light buzzed overhead, and somewhere down the hall a phone rang. "And did it?"

Lana nodded but said nothing.

Finally, Marlow stood. But her movements were slower now, less rigid. She pushed her chair in quietly instead of shoving it.

"I'm going to talk to the DA," she said. "And to the medical examiner. And to the department psychiatrist."

Lana looked up, confused. "Why?"

Marlow hesitated, then answered honestly. "Because you don't need another interrogation. You need help."

Lana stared at her, eyes red and swollen. "Help?"

Marlow nodded. “You’re not well, Lana. And I don’t think a jail cell is going to fix that.”

Fear flickered across Lana’s face. “What will happen to me?”

Marlow rested her hand lightly on the back of the chair. “You’ll be evaluated. Doctors. Psychiatrists. People who understand this kind of thing. You won’t be alone in a cell wondering what’s real and what isn’t.”

Lana’s voice came out small. “Am I going to prison?”

Marlow didn’t answer directly. “Right now, we’re going to make sure you’re safe. And that you can’t hurt yourself or anyone else.”

Lana swallowed hard. “I didn’t want to hurt anyone.”

“I know,” Marlow said quietly.

She turned toward the door, pausing with her hand on the handle.

“Detective,” Lana called weakly.

Marlow stopped but didn’t turn around.

“The calls were real,” Lana said. “He was real.”

Marlow closed her eyes for a brief moment, then opened them again. “I know you believe that,” she said softly. “And that’s exactly why we’re going to get you help.”

She opened the door and stepped out into the hallway. The metal door shut behind her with a heavy, echoing thud. And Lana sat alone in the cold, windowless room, tears sliding silently down her face as the red light in the corner continued its steady blinking.

THE CITY HERALD

Tuesday Edition

Engineer Found NGRI in November Killings

Court orders psychiatric commitment after testimonies lead to Not Guilty by Reason of Insanity verdict

By Joey Green | Staff Writer

A judge ruled Monday that 26-year-old civil engineer, Lana Davis, is not criminally responsible by reason of insanity in the fatal stabbing of bartender Jeremey Koss and the arson at the apartment of Charlotte Bennett, concluding a months-long case.

Davis, who had no prior criminal history, was accused of killing Koss behind the Moss & Oak bar late last fall. Prosecutors initially charged her with one count of second-degree murder, but the case shifted dramatically after a detective, Caroline Marlow, fought for a psychiatric evaluation. This revealed severe psychological deterioration following the death of her husband in a hit-and-run accident nine months earlier.

Judge Gillian Winston delivered the decision in the courtroom Monday morning:

> “The court finds that Ms. Davis was suffering from a significant mental disease at the time of the offense, impairing her ability to distinguish reality

from delusion. She will not be sentenced to prison, but she will be committed to a secure psychiatric facility until doctors determine she is no longer a danger to herself or others."

The Crime

According to police evidence, Koss was found behind the Moss & Oak bar shortly after midnight, suffering approximately 43 stab wounds. Surveillance footage placed Davis near the scene shortly before the attack. She was arrested one month later at a downtown café without resistance.

At the time of her arrest, police said Davis appeared calm and cooperative. During her initial interrogation, she told detectives she believed Koss had murdered her deceased husband.

The case took a darker turn when investigators uncovered more evidence, late in the trial, linking Davis to an earlier tragedy: a fire that killed her best friend, Charlotte Bennett, the day before the stabbing.

Forensic evidence placed Davis at the scene shortly before the fire began. However, medical experts testified that Davis had no memory of the incident and was suffering from severe dissociative episodes.

Why is This Case Different?

While pleading guilty by insanity is not uncommon, the degree to which Miss Davis had truly lost her mind was unlike any other courtroom has seen.

Lana Davis was convinced she was receiving nightly phone calls from her dead husband. These phone calls, which later led her to both kill her best friend, Charlotte Bennett, and Jeremey Koss.

Lana's memory has baffled the psychiatrist. She appears to have no recollection of murdering Charlotte and can't even express a possible motive, but remembers the night of killing Jeremey clearly. Lana also recalls conversations that never occurred, such as speaking with her deceased next-door neighbor, Juliet Kent, who passed away in May of 2025.

Dr. Chandler Kingston, a forensic psychiatrist who evaluated Davis over several weeks, told the court:

> "Ms. Davis developed what we classify as grief-induced psychotic disorder with dissociative features. She experienced auditory hallucinations and constructed a narrative in which a third party was responsible for the trauma in her life.
>
> Her actions were not driven by criminal intent but by delusional thinking and unresolved trauma."

Park testified that Davis's belief in the nightly phone calls was "unshakable" and not the product of deception.

“She wasn’t lying,” Park said. “She truly believed those calls were real.”

The Diagnosis

Medical experts from both the prosecution and defense agreed on Davis’s condition, though they differed on its severity.

The final court-accepted diagnosis included:

- Persistent Complex Bereavement Disorder
- Grief-Induced Psychotic Disorder
- Dissociative Episodes with Memory Gaps
- Severe Major Depressive Disorder

Doctors testified that Davis’s symptoms included:

- Auditory hallucinations of her deceased husband
- Fixed delusional beliefs about responsibility for his death
- Periods of memory loss surrounding violent events
- Obsessive nightly routines tied to the time of the alleged calls

What Happens Next

Instead of prison, Davis will be transferred to Ridgeview State Psychiatric Facility, a secure hospital that houses individuals found not criminally responsible.

Under state law:

- She must remain in treatment indefinitely
- A review board will evaluate her condition every 6–12 months
- Release is only possible if doctors and the court agree she is no longer dangerous

Legal analysts say that, in many cases, individuals committed under insanity rulings spend as much or more time in psychiatric facilities than they would have in prison.

A Community Still Processing

The Moss & Oak bar has since reopened under new management. A small framed photo of Koss now hangs behind the counter, surrounded by handwritten notes from regular customers.

One note reads:

"You always remembered my drink. We won't forget you."

In her closing remarks, Judge Whitmore addressed the broader tragedy behind the case.

> "This courtroom has seen two deaths, a destroyed friendship, and a life undone by grief. Justice, in this instance, must include treatment, not just punishment."

Epilogue

There is nothing quite like grief. It can trick you into thinking you've escaped, only to yank you back when you least expect it. For Lana Davis, it was a phone call at exactly 1:43 am. A phone call that no one else ever heard. Now trapped within the sterile blank walls of a mental hospital, Lana listens to the hum of the fluorescent yellow lights and counts the ticks on the unmarked clock face. The silence around her echoes the voices in her mind. His voice in her mind. Nurses pass by and whisper softly about the woman who talks to the dead and smiles at nothing. The outside world moves on, but Lana is stuck, waiting for that impossible call to come again. Her shadow, darker than ever, casts behind her in that plain white room.